



To subscribe,
give a missed call at
9828331787
or scan QR code



Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirappalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna

CORRECTIVE STEPS
CPI(M) top brass begins 3-day meet in Keralam
SOUTH » PAGE 3

GUTERRES REFLECTS
'Security Council is paralysed but UN not broken'
NEWS » PAGE 4

DISCUSSIONS ONGOING
UCC in all NDA-ruled States by 2029: Shah
NEWS » PAGE 6

PROACTIVE APPROACH
Countering the changing face of terror
India is moving away from defensive mode
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8

NEW QUEEN
Rybakina clinches her maiden US Open title
SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



Strike on Iranian commercial ship leaves one dead

CAIRO
An Iranian commercial ship was struck in a "terrorist enemy" attack early on Sunday off the Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz, killing one person, Iranian state media said, a day before Tehran plans to brief countries in the region on its contested efforts to manage shipping traffic at the crucial waterway. » PAGE 14

THE HINDU
greet its readers on the occasion of
Vinayaka Chaturthi
There will be no issue of THE HINDU dated September 15, 2026 as Vinayaka Chaturthi is a holiday
Readers can access the online edition at www.thehindu.com

Cong. criticises 'capitulation' on Chinese border

NEW DELHI
Countering the Centre's claim of "steady progress" in ties with Beijing, the Congress referred to the June 2020 conflict in Galwan, China's alleged territorial advances in Arunachal Pradesh and Ladakh, its support for Pakistan, and growing trade deficit, saying the evidence pointed to a "calibrated capitulation". » PAGE 4

S-400 destroyed Pak. aircraft at range of '314 km'

NEW DELHI
An S-400 air-defence unit of the Indian Air Force destroyed a Pakistani special-mission aircraft at a distance of 314 km during Operation Sindoor, marking one of the longest surface-to-air engagements claimed by India and demonstrating the IAF's long-range air-defence capability, a Defence Ministry annual report said. » PAGE 6

10 PLA combined arms brigades 'remain on LAC'

NEW DELHI
There was a significant reduction in the deployment of China's People's Liberation Army (PLA) along India's northern borders in 2025, even as Beijing continued to maintain 10 combined arms brigade-sized formations in areas along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and in traditional training areas, said a report of the Defence Ministry. » PAGE 6

PM Modi flags weaponisation of technology and critical minerals

BRICS should focus on concrete results, not 'merely ideas,' says Modi; PM highlights initiatives to bolster supply chains, and boost resilience against pandemics and climate disasters; there is also agreement on an early warning system, the PM states

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Warning against the "weaponisation" of technology and access to critical minerals, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday highlighted new BRICS initiatives to strengthen supply chains and increase resilience against disruptions, pandemics, and climate disasters.

The rising number of global conflicts has an increasingly negative and far-reaching impact on the lives of ordinary people, Mr. Modi said on the final day of the BRICS Summit here. As BRICS enters its third decade, the world expects concrete results from the group, not "merely ideas and commitments".

Boosting resilience
"The weaponisation of technology and critical minerals can hinder our shared progress," Mr. Modi said. "Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in the adoption of technology. Pandemics, climate disasters, and supply-chain



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a session on the second day of the BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, on Sunday. PTI

disruptions have shown that in today's interconnected world, no crisis remains confined to a single region."

Therefore, he said, the BRICS nations have worked to strengthen resilience, with a focus on identifying challenges in time, being prepared, and taking prompt action.

"With this approach, we have agreed on a BRICS Integrated Early Warning System for the prevention of, and response to, infectious diseases," Mr. Modi said. "Early Warning Data Integration Guidelines have been prepared for

disaster management. The BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Cooperation Framework will help make our supply chains more reliable and resilient."

The BRICS Incubator Network will connect startups and incubators across member states, while a BRICS Startup Innovation Fund has been proposed to promote innovative and scalable solutions.

"The BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture will create new opportunities for farmers," Mr. Modi said. "Through this initiative, AI, geospatial technology, and Digital Public In-

Putin suggests BRICS grain trade to fight sanctions

NEW DELHI
Under sanctions by Western powers over the war with Ukraine, Russian President Vladimir Putin on Sunday proposed a new insurance mechanism and a collaborative grain market among BRICS nations for economic growth of the bloc. » PAGE 4

frastructure will be connected to the real needs of farmers."

The Prime Minister also highlighted BRICS CONNECT, aimed at promoting skills, employability, women in the workforce, social security, and capacity building.

Centre of excellence
"To connect small enterprises with knowledge, finance, and new markets, we have initiated the BRICS MSME Cooperation Portal," Mr. Modi added. "The BRICS Urban Mobility Hub has been established to facilitate the sharing of best

practices among our cities."

Regarding the sustainability pillar of India's strategy for BRICS, he said that a BRICS Digital Centre of Excellence has been established for smart grids and energy storage.

"This will help make our clean energy systems more reliable, efficient, and accessible," Mr. Modi said. The Centres of Excellence for Agro-Ecology and Regenerative Agriculture will connect traditional knowledge with modern science. The principles developed for community-based climate adaptation will make indigenous knowledge an important foundation for climate action."

He noted that the Global South's confidence in BRICS has grown because "their voices are heard, their experiences are respected, and solutions are developed not for them, but together with them".

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8
DETAILED COVERAGE
» PAGE 5

BRICS should ensure the world is free from 'double standards': Xi

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Sunday called on the BRICS countries to "rally the Global South" to ensure that an increasingly volatile international order was "free from double standards", even as he offered a five-point AI and smart manufacturing initiative to take forward the grouping's digital future.

Speaking at the summit in New Delhi, Mr. Xi said the global landscape was currently "volatile and fraught with risks and challenges". "To bring stability to the world and make it a better place, BRICS countries must seize the historical initiative, rally the Global South, be an active, stabilising, and positive force in international affairs, and advance the well-being of all humanity," he said, according to remarks released by the Foreign Ministry in Beijing.

Mr. Xi did not name the United States. Still, Chinese officials have increasingly aimed at Washington for how they see its exercise of power in a self-described "rules-based order", especially after recent actions in Venezue-



Xi Jinping

la and the war with Iran. "The logic of 'might makes right' does not hold, and should have been discarded long ago," Mr. Xi said. "Global South countries should jointly defend the rule of law in international affairs, safeguard the basic norms of international relations, including sovereign equality, non-interference in internal affairs, and the peaceful settlement of disputes, and ensure that international law and international rules are applied to all, free from double standards."

Mr. Xi put forward five AI- and technology-focused initiatives to establish 'AI open source community', 'open ecosystem for AI', 'special economic zone partnership', 'digital ecosystem cloud platform' and 'science and technology talent development'.



A screenshot from a video released by the Houthis on Saturday shows fighters near military vehicles in southern Yemen. AP

Houthis attack Saudi 'again' as Yemen govt. prepares to retaliate

Associated Press
CAIRO

Iran-aligned Houthi militia in Yemen on Sunday claimed new attacks on Saudi Arabia, as internationally recognised Yemeni government described the rebels' swift advance along the Red Sea coast as a "painful" development in a new front in the Iran war.

The Houthis claimed more attacks with missiles and drones on Saudi Arabia, which supports Yemen's internationally recognised government. A Houthi military spokesperson, Brigadier General Yahya Saree, claimed in a statement that the group targeted a military base in Saudi Sharurah province in Saudi Arabia's Najran region.

The Saudi Arabian civil defence said a projectile fell in al-Tawwal governorate near the border with Yemen along the Red Sea, injuring two people. There was no statement from

Saudi Arabia on Sunday on any new attacks targeting the Houthis, who have been hitting the kingdom's oil infrastructure and shipping as part of a recently declared blockade. However, Houthi media reported on Sunday that Saudi Arabia had carried out two strikes on Saada, in the north of Yemen.

While the rebels, who now control the Red Sea coast and the crucial Bab el-Mandeb Strait, have said there is no threat to commercial shipping, markets remain wary and oil prices have risen again. Meanwhile, a government official in Yemen said its forces will return to the coast and fight back. Sultan al-Arada of the presidential council in Yemen said late on Saturday that forces "are currently regrouping and will return to the battle in one form or another."

PIPELINE OUTAGE IMPACTS
» PAGE 14

Royal salute



Warm welcome: Elephants arrive in a procession at the Mysuru Palace on Sunday for the Dasara festival. Caparisoned elephants are a highlight of the celebrations and draw considerable tourist attention. M. A. SRIRAM

Russian drone strikes Kyiv-Warsaw passenger train

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

A Russian drone struck a Kyiv-to-Warsaw passenger train near the Polish border on Sunday but caused no casualties, Ukraine and Poland said, as Moscow steps up attacks in the fifth year of its invasion. The strike was reported just two kilometres from the Polish border.

Poland, a NATO member, said a second drone struck near a border crossing, prompting Foreign Minister Radoslaw Sikorski to

accuse Russian President Vladimir Putin of "escalating" the conflict.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Moscow struck the train "deliberately" and accused Russia of attacking rail and energy infrastructure as well as civilian buildings across the country.

"It is precisely to prevent these strikes from spreading further into Europe that Ukrainian men and women fight every day, give their lives, and do not allow the aggression to expand," he said.



Firefighters extinguish a car of the drone-hit train in Lutsk, Ukraine. REUTERS

"Putin is escalating," Polish Foreign Minister Sikorski said on social media.

The country's PKP Inter-city rail service said the train was travelling from Kyiv to Warsaw with 206 passengers onboard.

Way out of Ukraine

With Ukrainian airspace closed, trains to neighbouring Poland have been one of the main routes out of the war-torn country, often carrying refugees and packed with women and children.

Poland's Interior Minister Marcin Kierwinski said one drone struck near the Dorohusk-Yagodyn border

crossing, while the other hit the passenger train.

Russia said on Sunday it struck "railway infrastructure" in western Ukraine used to "transport military cargo" from Europe.

"Strikes have continued on railway infrastructure in the western regions of Ukraine, which are used to transport military cargo from European countries," Moscow's Defence Ministry said in a statement.

Russian attacks killed at least two people on Sunday, both in the frontline city of Kramatorsk.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The BRICS must play a greater role in building a more balanced, inclusive and just international order, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Sunday while stressing that resilience, cooperation, and sustainability should be translated into practical action.

Taking a swipe at Western powers, he slammed "unilateral sanctions", saying they were directly impacting global food security and welfare of people.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 5

INBRIEF



Nagina MP detained while visiting slain trader’s family

Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) president and Nagina MP Chandrashekhar Azad was stopped and detained in Uttar Pradesh’s Barabanki on Sunday while en route to Gonda to meet the family of slain trader Vinod Kumar Sahani, police said. According to Masoli SHO Ashwini Kumar, Mr. Azad was travelling from Lucknow to Gonda when police stopped his convoy at Shahpur toll plaza, took him into custody and escorted him to a circuit house in Ramnagar. Mr. Azad’s detention angered his supporters, some of whom allegedly broke the toll barrier, leading to brief chaos. PTI

M.P. hooch tragedy: wanted man caught after encounter

A man wanted in connection with the hooch tragedy in Madhya Pradesh’s Sagar district that claimed 16 lives was apprehended after a brief encounter with police early on Sunday, officers said. The 21-year-old accused, Shivanjay Rajput, who was carrying a bounty of ₹30,000, suffered a gunshot wound to his leg during the face-off, the police said. With this, the number of accused arrested in the spurious liquor consumption case has gone up to 19, police sources said. A country-made .315-bore pistol, three live cartridges, a mobile phone, and a motorcycle were recovered from Mr. Rajput’s possession. PTI

Nephew is spreading rumours about my health, says Mayawati

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

BSP president Mayawati hit out at her nephew Akash Anand on Sunday accusing him of spreading what she described as false rumours about her health.

The allegations came days after Ms. Mayawati removed Mr. Anand as the party’s national coordinator.

Addressing a press conference in Lucknow, the four-time Uttar Pradesh

Chief Minister said the expelled party leader had called her personal secretary, Alok Kumar, and asked whether she was unwell.

“Those expelled from the party spread the rumour that I am ill. The office in-charge received a call from Akash Anand. He asked about my health... (Alok) told him that I was doing fine. At this, Akash hung up after asking that ‘Behen ji’ (the BSP president) not be informed of

this conversation,” Ms. Mayawati told a press conference in Lucknow.

The BSP chief urged BSP workers to mobilise for the upcoming elections. “We have to form the government in Uttar Pradesh,” Ms. Mayawati added.

Akash Anand – the son of Mayawati’s brother Anand Kumar and once her chosen political successor – had been entrusted with key party responsibilities but was removed several times since 2024.

Press Trust of India
PANAJI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Goa Forward Party (GFP) on Sunday announced their pre-poll alliance, ‘Goa First’, for the 2027 Assembly election in the coastal State, offering what they described as a “non-BJP, non-Congress alternative” to voters.

Making the announcement, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal told reporters in Panaji that the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would not secure a majority in the upcoming election and that the Goa First alliance would form the next government.

‘Have learnt a lesson’ He also said AAP had learnt a lesson after seven of its Rajya Sabha members merged with the BJP and would be “extra cautious” in future about picking candidates.

“The people of Goa want a change. Goa First



AAP’s Goa in-charge and Delhi LoP Atishi, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, GJP president Vijai Sardesai and other leaders at Sunday’s event. PTI

will form the government. We will win on our own,” Mr. Kejriwal said at a press conference with GFP president Vijai Sardesai, Delhi’s Leader of the Opposition and AAP’s Goa in-charge Atishi, and others. He said both parties are equal partners in the alliance.

Mr. Sardesai said the tie-up would provide an alternative to the government which, he said, is “full of defectors”. He said the BJP had not received a com-

plete mandate in the previous election and even the Congress could not deny the possibility of another round of defections.

‘Open to more parties’ “It was important to form the alliance. We have formed the alliance with Goa’s interests as the focus,” Mr. Sardesai said, adding that the alliance is open to other political forces. “This alliance has not closed the door. It is open

to like-minded political forces. Many people have approached us, including leaders from both the [national] parties,” he said.

In the current 40-seat Goa Legislative Assembly, AAP has two MLAs while the GFP has one. Mr. Sardesai’s party was an alliance partner of the Congress in the 2022 election.

Speaking to reporters, Mr. Kejriwal called out the “betrayal” of the seven MPs, including Raghav Chadha and Sandeep Pathak, who merged with the BJP. “It is a matter of great regret that our Rajya Sabha MPs left the party. They betrayed the party. The party sent them to the Rajya Sabha; the people did not send them,” the AAP chief said.

“We believe that this is a lesson for us because such a thing has never happened in AAP before. From now on, before sending anyone to the Rajya Sabha, we will scrutinise the person thoroughly and ensure that he is the right person,” he added.

T.N. bypolls: Left parties to contest as separate front

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/TIRUCHI

The Communist Party of India (CPI) and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] have decided to contest the October 6 byelections in Tamil Nadu without aligning with any formation. The CPI will contest from Dharapuram while the CPI(M) will contest from Madurantakam, CPI State secretary M. Veerapandian said on Sunday.

With the Left parties’ decision to contest as a separate front, there will be a multi-cornered contest in these two Assembly constituencies. The alliances led by the TVK, the DMK and the AIADMK have already announced their candidates. Seemant Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) will go it alone.

Candidates to be named Speaking to reporters at Balan Illam, the CPI State headquarters in Chennai, Mr. Veerapandian said the candidates would be announced on September 15. “The CPI had already decided not to be part of any alliance. At the executive committee meeting held on Saturday and Sunday,



M. Veerapandian

there was also a strong view that the same stand should continue,” he said.

“Respecting the people’s verdict, the Left parties extended outside support to the TVK to form a government, to avoid Governor’s Rule, which would have been indirect rule by the BJP,” he said.

According to him, the byelections were imposed on people. “It has been decided that the Left parties will face these byelections from the position we have already taken: not to be part of any alliance. We appeal to democratic forces to extend their support to the Left parties,” he said.

CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam said though the two Left parties had decided to contest the bypolls separately, the CPI(M) would continue to extend outside support to the TVK-led government.

Marandi alleges cover-up in probe into JPSC-JSSC exam ‘irregularities’

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

Leader of the Opposition in the Jharkhand Assembly Babul Marandi on Sunday alleged a “cover-up” and protection of influential people in the ongoing CID probe into “irregularities” in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) recruitment exams.

Mr. Marandi also questioned the lack of videogra-

phy while recording statements in the case. He added that the direction of the probe suggests an exercise aimed solely at suppressing the truth and shielding the “big fish”.

In a post on X, Mr. Marandi stated complaints are surfacing that confirm earlier apprehensions. He claimed that when individuals detained or interrogated in the case reveal details regarding bribery transactions and the involvement of high-profile pol-

iticians, officials, or their intermediaries, those specific parts are being omitted from their recorded statements.

‘Pressure applied’ The senior BJP leader also alleged that some junior officials involved in the investigation, on the condition of anonymity, have reported that their senior departmental officers are pressuring them not to include such statements in the official records.

SPOTLIGHT

Nikhil M Babu

It is around 11 a.m. and the downpour is intensifying. Mahesh Saini, 40, with a sack slung over his left shoulder and a stick in his right hand, reaches the Nehru Nagar Atal Canteen, an initiative of the Delhi government to provide meals at ₹5 each. As he enters, a man at a counter inside shouts, waving his hand: “Bora bahar (Leave the sack outside).”

Mahesh, a ragpicker, puts down the white plastic sack, ties its mouth carefully, and leaves it next to the door. He props up his stick there too. His once-white T-shirt and his hair tell the same story: neither has been washed for a while.

He walks to the counter and the man behind a laptop holds out a webcam and takes his photo. “Now blink,” the operator says, so that the camera can scan his iris. Mahesh silently obeys, as he knows the drill by now. He produces a ₹5 coin, moves to the next counter and picks up a steel plate. A woman serving the meals wastes no time in filling the plate’s compartments with hot short-grain rice, yellow pulse with some *rajma*, a runny vegetable of potato with a little brinjal, and four thin tawa *rotis*.

Mahesh settles at one of the six metal tables with attached metal stools. “Kha-

na mujhe achha lagta hai (I like the food),” says Mahesh, who collects plastic bottles and other trash. For this, he earns ₹200 a day. “I end up spending almost all the money,” he says, adding that he sleeps on the footpath.

For thousands of people like Mahesh, Atal Canteens have become a daily stop for a cooked meal, which costs them little. Since December 2025, the Delhi government has started similar Atal Canteens at 100 locations across the city, giving out close to 50,000 meals every day. Each canteen has a daily capacity of 1,000 meals, 500 each for lunch and dinner.

The contract for running the 100 canteens has been awarded to 11 different companies or NGOs. The vendor charges ₹30 for each meal, of which it collects ₹5 from the individual and ₹25 from the government.

At the launch of the scheme on December 25 last year, the birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that the government’s aim was to make sure that no one in Delhi goes hungry.

India ranks 102nd out of 123 countries in the Global Hunger Index report, with a score of 25.8 that places the country in the “serious” hunger category.

Gupta says the subsidised food network has crossed the milestone of 1 crore meals served. She

In Delhi, food to fill a stomach

For thousands, Atal Canteens have become a daily stop for a meal that costs ₹5. Spread across 100 locations in the city, these spaces serve around 50,000 meals a day, attracting people from different walks of life



A filling stop: The Atal Canteen in Anand Vihar, located near the inter-State bus terminal and railway station, that is frequented by commuters and workers. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

adds that the government is open to improving the menu, but every change will be driven by nutrition, evidence, affordability and the public preference.

Respite for thousands Though most canteens have come up near slum clusters, a few are located near hospitals, colleges and bus terminals, drawing people from diverse backgrounds. The pulse and the vegetable change after every meal at each canteen. Unlike Oliver Twist, who was admonished for asking for

a second serving, people at many Atal Canteens can refill their plates.

However, Appu Rao, 48, from Andhra Pradesh, says, “Modi is giving (subsidised) food now, but in the South it has been given for a long time.” He gets into a conversation with another person about how the food was better when the canteen opened and it is still better at the Atal Canteen in Andrews Ganj in south Delhi. “The food at the Gurudwara is better. Sometimes, on Sundays, you get *paneer* also there,” he says, a view that is shared by

some others too.

As the afternoon wears on, food delivery agents and auto drivers join for the lunch. “The food is not bad. According to the rides I get, I eat at one of these canteens twice a day. I’m saving about ₹3,000 per month,” says Harish Babu, 28, an autorickshaw driver. Many others also pitch in to say that this saves them money because food elsewhere costs between ₹60 and ₹70.

Mukesh Kumar Aggarwal, adviser, Micro Education and Social Welfare Society, a non-profit

organisation that runs 10 Atal Canteens, says, “For a canteen like the one in Anand Vihar we make around 125 kg of *dal* plus *sabzi*, 100 kg of rice and 2,000 *rotis*.” “After paying the workers, we make maybe 50 paise per plate or sometimes just break even, but we are a non-profit and our aim is to feed the hungry and provide employment,” he adds.

However, staff at the canteens complain they are not even paid the minimum wage. A woman in her 40s serving food at one of the canteens says she gets only ₹8,500 per month. “We come here at 10 in the morning and leave only after 9 at night and get only two days off a month. The money we get is very low and there is no time to work anywhere else,” she says.

Reetika Khera, professor at IIT Delhi, says there are about a dozen major States in India that run subsidised canteens. In her recent book, *Freebies or Rights*, she talks about the importance of public canteens in ensuring food security, based on her team’s 2023 study of 174 such canteens across three States. She says that in terms of scale, Rajasthan was the best example at the time of the study. In terms of quality, the best was Kerala. But the meals start at ₹30 there. There is also the option of ordering a non-vegetarian dish by paying extra.

Though only 17 kilo-

metres from Nehru Nagar, the Atal Canteen near the University of Delhi’s north campus stands in stark contrast, with students at almost all six tables. It is cleaner and everyone is given spoons. The canteen, inaugurated by the Chief Minister on August 16, abuts Chhatra Marg (Students’ Road), which leads to many well-known colleges.

A group of three students, who have completed their master’s degrees in political science, are busy eating and chatting. “For ₹5, this is good. What will you get for ₹5 these days?” says Sunil, 25.

Sitting at the other end of the table, Rahul Thakur, 25, lifts his head and joins the conversation. “*Mirch masala kam hai* (there is less masala), but I can save about ₹4,000 a month by eating here,” says Thakur, who is doing his PhD in history.

Past experiments

In 2010, the then Congress government in Delhi launched the Jan Aahar scheme, under which vans started providing lunch and dinner at ₹15 each.

After the AAP government came to power, they started ‘Aam aadmi canteen’ at the government-run LNJP Hospital in 2017 to provide meals at ₹10, but the scheme was not scaled up. Professor Khera says when a new party comes to power in a State, they try to undermine the public canteens started by the

previous government and people end up suffering due to it. “There should be some legal protection for public canteens, so that they can continue to function despite the change in governments,” she says.

Where commuters eat The Atal Canteens are a hit at many locations, one of them being Anand Vihar on the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border, a stone’s throw away from the interstate bus terminal and railway station.

Twenty-three-year-old Tejender Saini and his wife eat quickly.

“We work at a tile factory in Punjab and are here to meet our relatives for Raksha Bandhan,” he says. “At the bus stand someone told us that we would get ‘*bhar pet khana*’ (food to fill one’s stomach) for just ₹5 and we thought we would check it out,” he says, adding that he liked the food.

But for some, the canteen itself is the destination. Rita Devi, 34, a widow, travelled with her eight-year-old daughter for about half an hour to reach the canteen.

“I lost my job as a security guard at a mall about two months back as I fell ill. I have been looking for a job for the past two weeks, but I can’t find anything,” Devi says, as she wipes her tears. “I’m thinking of coming here every day till I find a job.”

nikhil.m
@thehindu.co.in

INBRIEF



Swollen streams cut off tribal villages in Andhra Pradesh

Continuous rain disrupted normal life in several tribal areas of Alluri Sitharama Raju district in Andhra Pradesh over the past three days, with swollen streams, washed-away culverts, and inundated farms cutting off some villages from the plains. However, the rain began to recede on Sunday afternoon and water levels in the streams are expected to decrease on Monday. Officials have been asked to monitor vulnerable areas, road connectivity, and stream crossings.

Seven arrested for poaching wild animals in Karnataka

The Yadgir Regional Forest Division in Karnataka conducted a search on Saturday and arrested seven persons for alleged illegal wildlife poaching in the reserved forest area. Officials seized the poached animals, including burnt remains of two peacocks, two live turtles, and 12 live crabs. They also confiscated six country-made guns and other arms from the accused. A case has been registered and all accused were presented before the court and remanded in judicial custody.

Umar Khalid documentary screening put off at NLSIU

After Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and other right-wing activists raised objections, the screening of a documentary on activist Umar Khalid at the National Law School of India University (NLSIU) in Bengaluru on Monday was postponed. Lalit Vachani's documentary *Prisoner No 626710 is Present* was screened at the NLSIU even last year on Political Prisoners Day, said students. This time, organisers postponed it citing "logistical and security reasons".

CPI(M)'s State committee meet under way in Keralam

During the extended three-day meeting, participants will debate a draft report on issues plaguing the party following its rout in the Assembly election in State; corrective steps on top of the agenda

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Corrective steps to overcome organisational weaknesses are on top of the agenda as the extended three-day State committee meeting of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) is progressing in Kozhikode, Keralam.

Select participants from across districts, and representatives of the party's organisations, will get a chance to air their views in an open debate on a draft report prepared by the State committee on the problems plaguing the CPI (M) following its rout in the Assembly elections in Ker-



Addressing gaps: CPI(M) leaders raise slogans ahead of the State committee meeting in Kozhikode, Keralam, on Sunday. K. RAGESH

alam. Opening the conference on Sunday morning, party general secretary M.A. Baby claimed that a situation akin to that of 1960, when the undivided Communist Party of India improved its vote percentage in elections but lost

power in the State, had happened in 2026 too.

"The creation of false perceptions against the CPI (M) began after the party-led front came back to power in 2021... One among them is that we have reached a deal with

the RSS and the BJP... We need to examine where we made mistakes in countering such campaigns," he said. He added that the party cadre should engage in criticism of others and of themselves.

Addressing the media earlier, State secretary M.V. Govindan said the central and State committees had brought out review reports on the party's weaknesses. "Our efforts will be to correct lapses and suggest improvement measures."

He also said that the attempt by the ED to implicate Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan in corruption cases was a way of attacking the party.

Narsipur town tense ahead of Ganesh fest

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/MYSURU

A police inspector's warning during a peace meet ahead of Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations in T. Narsipur town near Mysuru has whipped up a political storm in Karnataka.

Town police inspector Dhananjaya's reported warning to processionists against bursting crackers near a mosque (like last year) drew a strong response from the BJP, with

Leader of Opposition R. Ashok alleging the government was not allowing people to celebrate Ganesh festival in peace. Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar retorted by saying there was a conspiracy to disturb peace. He accused Mr. Ashok of trying to incite "communal passions".

The BJP also took out a protest march in Narsipur on Sunday. Dalit activists also gathered in the area, accusing the BJP of spreading communal poison.

Won't quit Cong., says ex-Telangana Minister

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Dismissing reports about quitting the Congress following her removal from the Telangana Cabinet, Warangal East MLA Konda Surekha said her family would remain with the party.

She hoped that her husband and former MLC Konda Muralidhar Rao would soon be offered a "chairman post" in any one of the State corporations. The

couple said that they would strive to make Rahul Gandhi the Prime Minister.

After her removal from the Cabinet following her daughter Sushmitha's comments against Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy, Ms. Surekha and Mr. Murali held a meeting with their supporters in Warangal on Sunday. Ms. Surekha reiterated that she did not bring any disrepute to the Minister's post and expressed anguish over her removal for "no valid reason".

Opposition leaders slam T.N. govt. over power cuts in State

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu is plagued by rampant power cuts, rise in the prices of essential commodities, and law and order issues under the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government, alleged Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin on Sunday.

"The people of Tamil Nadu today are facing various problems because of the party in power. Every day, a new problem keeps emerging. There are power cuts... The prices of essentials are on the rise. But when questions are raised, the Chief Minister is unable to answer. Because he is unable to answer, they are making defamatory allegations against the DMK and our leader [M.K. Stalin]," he said.

Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran said there had been "undeclared load shedding" in Tamil Nadu, compelling people to resort to agitations.

In a post on social media, Mr. Dhinakaran said the TVK-led government, which has been in office for over 120 days, had not addressed the issue of power shortage. Instead of taking steps for the provision of uninterrupted supply, the Minister concerned had been "digging time-barred allegations" and reopening "closed chapters", and this was condemnable, he alleged.

The TVK-led govern-



Udhayanidhi Stalin

ment is struggling to meet the high demand for power in the State due to its lackadaisical attitude, said AIADMK leader R.B. Udhayakumar.

He said in a statement that as the demand for power had increased to 21,000 megawatt (MW), the State was reeling under a shortage of 5,000 MW. "This has led to an undeclared power shutdown, subjecting people to untold sufferings," the former Minister said.

He added that the government had failed to take precautionary steps and predict the increase in power demand.

Minister's contention Minister for Revenue and Disaster Management K.A. Sengottaiyan said in Erode that Tamil Nadu was experiencing fewer power cuts compared with neighbouring States. Mr. Sengottaiyan said Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had been taking several measures to reduce power cuts and the State government was examining ways to store solar power for use at night.

Festive fever



In full swing: A girl selling small decorative umbrellas to adorn Ganesha idols makes her way through bustling festival shoppers in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, on Sunday. V. RAJU

Kottayam residents mobilise against Centre's ESA proposal

Hiran Unnikrishnan
KOTTAYAM

With just two weeks left in the 60-day window for filing objections and suggestions to the Centre's seventh draft notification on Ecologically Sensitive Areas (ESAs) in the Western Ghats, hundreds of settler families in the high ranges of Kottayam district in Kerala are bracing for a fresh battle to keep their homes and plantations out of the proposed ESA.

Four villages – Koottikal, Melukavu, Poonjar Thekkekkara and Teekoy – all in the Poonjar Assembly constituency, are on the proposed ESA map after being included in the draft notification issued on July 27. The proposal, estimat-

Four villages, all in Poonjar Assembly constituency, are on the proposed map

ed to affect around 70,000 people, has prompted residents, local bodies and various organisations, including the Catholic church, to step up their campaign against the move.

Agriculture is the backbone of these high range villages, with rubber, cardamom, coffee, pepper, coconut and banana among the major crops. Residents fear that bringing their land under the ESA could impose restrictions on plantations and hamper essential develop-

ment activities.

In the Koottikkal region, opposition has already moved beyond petitions. The local body has already convened special grama sabhas in all 14 wards, held an urgent council meeting and passed a resolution detailing its objections. The resolution will be forwarded to the State and Union governments.

Kerala Congress leader and Government Chief Whip Apu John Joseph said all possible steps would be taken to secure the exclusion of the villages.

"The concerns raised by the settlers have been presented with the Chief Minister. We are also continuing interactions to mobilise observations of farmer collectives," he said.



Satish Jarkiholi

Did not throw any challenge to ED, was misquoted

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI

Congress leader and Karnataka Public Works Minister Satish Jarkiholi said he was misquoted by some media outlets in reports about the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) searches at his residences.

"Some newspapers have reported that I have thrown a challenge at the ED to prove my overseas investment... I never said that," he said in a video message. "This is to clarify that I have not challenged the ED or any other agency... There is no question of posing any challenge to any agency," he added.

Mr. Jarkiholi said he was "working towards providing all documents to the ED regarding the issue".

"I have held three press conferences about the searches. I have repeatedly said we are cooperating with the ED and giving them all the records. However, some media outlets are reporting it in their own style, giving a wrong message to the general public and the agency concerned, he said. The leader said such statements "can be used against us" and urged the media "to report facts and our statements as they are."

Sibal calls for action against mid-term political defection

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Former Union Minister Kapil Sibal suggested that anyone who changes their political party during an active term should be disqualified from contesting elections and serving as an elected representative for the next five or 10 years.

He was delivering a talk on horse-trading and democracy at an event organised by the Kerala State Committee of the All India Lawyers Union on Sunday. "I have a confession: I am a Dimagi Naxal," he said.

The Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, which dealt with anti-defection, provided that a Member of Parliament would not be

Any inducement must be treated as corruption and not as the give-and-take of politics, he says

disqualified for defection if his political party merged with another political party and two-thirds of the party agreed to the merger. The clause, which was designed to protect political realignment, had now become the preferred instrument of wholesale defection, he noted.

"Those in power will not hurry to close a loophole that benefits them. If one accepts that two-thirds of a legislature party may rewrite an election, it will

subordinate the significance of the people's will to post-poll arithmetic," Mr. Sibal said.

He proposed the Tenth Schedule be reworked so that a merger would simply mean a merger of parties and not a mass walkout by legislators. "Any inducement, be it cash, office, contracts or the quashing of an enquiry, must be treated as corruption and not as the ordinary give-and-take of politics. The harm caused by the reality of political defection is not technical; it is foundational," Mr. Sibal said.

"When the citizens' mandate is treated as a transferable asset, the promise of a democracy ends up dishonoured," he said.

Keralam to consider buying electricity from other States and Central entities

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The Keralam government is exploring all possible options, including procuring electricity from other States and Central entities, to tide over the ongoing power shortage, Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph said on Sunday.

The State has been experiencing power outages, particularly at night.

Speaking to mediapersons, Mr. Joseph said steps would be taken to obtain necessary approval from the Kerala State Electricity Regulatory Commission to procure power at higher rates, if needed.

The government was also considering sending



Outage trouble: Left activists march towards a cantonment KSEB office in Thiruvananthapuram against power cuts. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) board members to other States to explore the availability of surplus power, he said.

The Minister said it was difficult to specify how long the power shortage would continue. Reduced availability of power amid deficient rainfall and a

sharp increase in consumption had contributed to the crisis, he said. "Demand has increased by more than 1,000 MW compared to last year, but generation has not increased correspondingly," Mr. Joseph said. The supply-demand imbalance has also pushed up prices, he said.

Antonio
Guterres

Putin seeks BRICS insurance, grain trade to fight curbs



Cong. flags border, trade concerns; accuses Centre of 'calibrated capitulation' to China

Poll panel gives Mamata, Ritabrata more time



Female offspring of spotted hyena inherit rank, resources, a taste for power

A ‘terrific’ new study has found that the youngest female cub born to an alpha female inherits her mother’s social status and also benefits from better access to food, allies, and breeding opportunities; over generations, these benefits accumulate, allowing a few privileged female lineages to produce more descendants

Kavi Bharathi R.
BENGALURU

Among people, it is common knowledge that privilege is often inherited. But according to new findings, hyenas also inherit resources and status, and not just their forebears’ genes, from their parents.

The findings were published recently in *Science Advances* – and they challenge the traditional evolutionary theories that assume males always face greater reproductive competition.

In the animal kingdom, the males are generally considered to be the dominant sex. They are stronger and more competitive. But spotted hyenas buck this trend.

Scientists at the Leibniz Institute for Zoo and Wildlife Research (Leibniz-IZW) in Berlin and the Institute of Evolutionary Science of Montpellier have found that in spotted hyenas, females dominate males not because they are bigger or stronger but because they have larger networks of social alliances.

The study also showed that female hyenas face more competition shaped by the inheritance of social rank across generations.

Alpha females

Marta Mosna, the lead author of the study and a researcher at Leibniz-IZW and the Ngorongoro Hyena Project, observed during her field visit in Africa that “male hyenas do not compete so much with each other”. Instead, they were found spending their time following the alpha female, the highest-ranking female hyenas, around.

“The males follow them wherever the female goes,” Ms. Mosna said. “They are staying close to her, spending a lot of time watching her, trying to connect with her, and trying to be friends with her.”

On the other hand, the competition is more fierce among the females. “This is not really what you would expect for the classical sex role that Darwin-Bateman predicts,” she said.

The Darwin-Bateman hypothesis proposes that reproductive inequality is greater among males. That is, between males and females, the males can father more offspring than females and this is why they compete more among themselves for access to mates. In mammals, the females also invest more in each reproductive event than males do – since they bear the physiological costs of pregnancy and lactation – they are more selective about mating. These predictions, formalised as the Darwin-Bateman paradigm, have been confirmed across many mammalian species.



Clan matriarch?: A spotted hyena in Etosha National Park, Namibia. SHARP PHOTOGRAPHY (CC BY-SA)

However, among spotted hyenas, the researchers found the females killing off the cubs of other females, despite all living in a matrilineal society in which the individuals were related to each other.

These and other observations supported the researchers’ conclusion that the daughters of ‘elite’ families could build powerful family lineages over time – thus also challenging one of evolutionary biology’s classic paradigms.

Clues in Lemala

For their study, the researchers studied hyenas belonging to eight resident clans in the Ngorongoro Crater in Tanzania. Their work spanned 29 years of data, eight generations, and 2,743 wild spotted hyenas.

The team used faecal samples to track paternity. These samples contained epithelial-rich mucus. “We need DNA information, which we normally take from the mucus around the faeces,” Dr. Mosna said. “We need to look at the males and wait for him to defecate. And then, when he leaves, be sure that this was his poop to do paternity analysis.”

“It is not always easy,” she continued. “Sometimes they even defecate in the water, and then it is gone, or sometimes after they eat it is a bit too liquid – it is not very pleasant to put your hand on. It can also be a bit challenging, but fortunately, our field assistants are very well trained and very good with it.”

For one clan that the team called ‘Lemala’, the researchers pieced together a 30-year genealogical tree and found that almost all the living members had descended from a single founding female lineage.

This led them to investigate how such extreme reproductive inequality could arise, which in turn led to the idea of the social inheritance of rank: since a mother’s social position is passed to her female cub, it could give that lineage an advantage increasing across generations.

When nepotism pays

The youngest female cub born to an alpha female inherits her mother’s social status and also benefits from better access to food, allies, and breeding opportunities. Over generations, these benefits accumulate, allowing a few privileged female lineages to produce more descendants.

“Inheriting the privilege ... means that you have better access to food and nutrition. They grow faster and survive longer. They also have a better position in the social network, which is also very important for hyenas,” Ms. Mosna said.

“This research teaches us that nothing is fixed. Sex roles are not fixed, like how a male or a female should behave; how our society should behave is not fixed by genetics. Only social processes can actually change society in a meaningful way.”

“This is a terrific paper that breaks a lot of new ground and serves as a powerful testament to the value of long-term field studies,” Kay E. Holekamp, a Michigan State University distinguished professor who was not involved in it, said.

Beyond hyenas

The researchers are now exploring whether similar patterns of socially inherited reproductive inequality occur in other animal species.

They have said they also want to investigate whether female hyenas invest differently in male and female cubs depending on their social rank. High-ranking females may invest more in female cubs to pass on their privileged position while lower-ranking females may favour male cubs, Ms. Mosna said.

“This study has broad implications for how we understand animal societies: social structures can transmit advantages across generations and thereby shape competition, inequality, and evolutionary outcomes,” Amiyaal Ilany of Tel Aviv University said.

“It also shows why inheritance should not be viewed as purely genetic. Socially inherited rank, relationships, and access to resources can have lasting effects on fitness and on the composition of future generations.”

(Kavi Bharathi R. is a science writer based at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru. bharathi.colors@gmail.com)

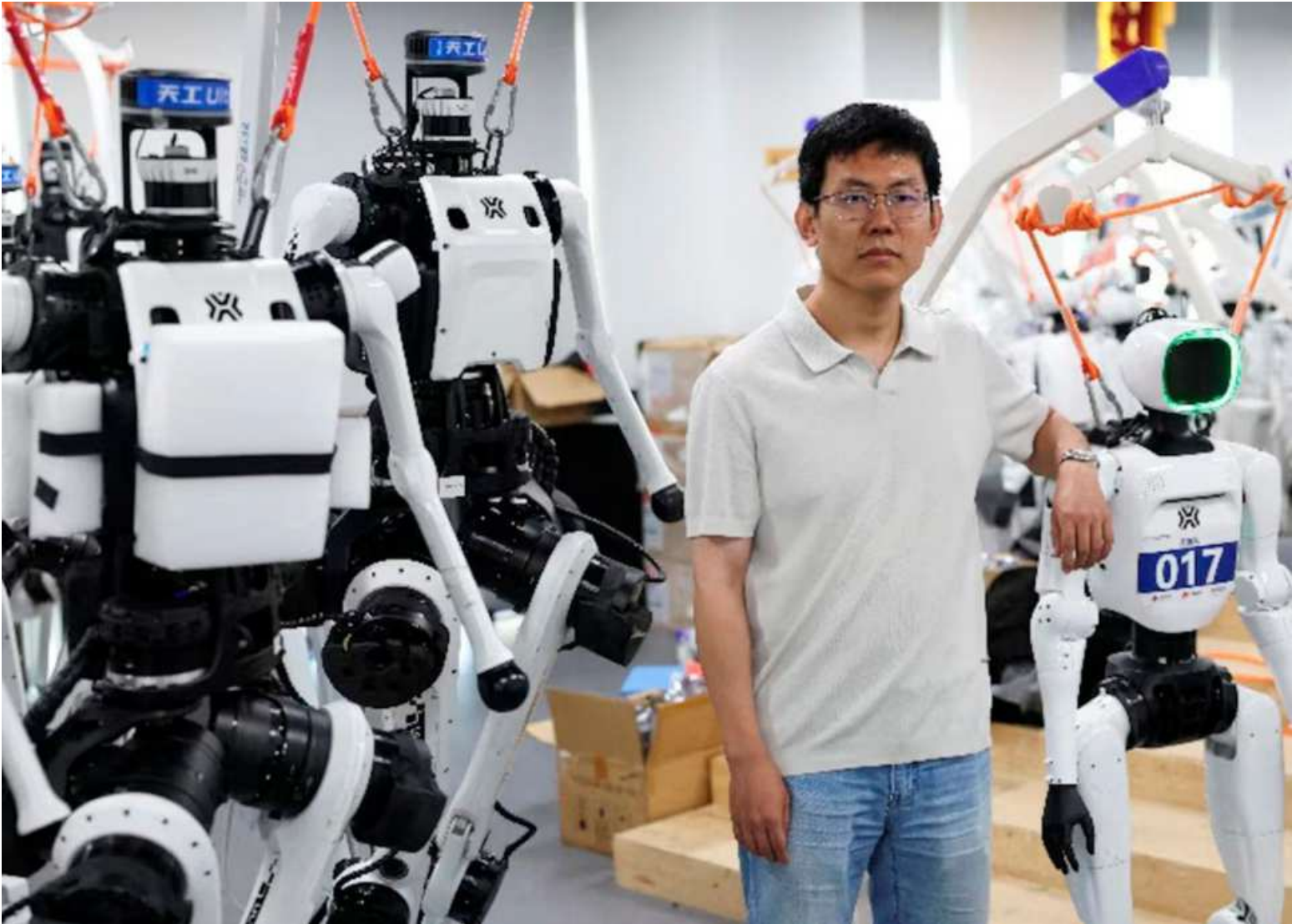
THE GIST

A team of researchers tracked 2,743 wild spotted hyenas across eight clans in Tanzania over 30 years, using DNA from mucus in faecal samples to determine paternity

By building a 30-year genealogical tree for one clan, they found that nearly all living members descended from a single founding female lineage

The researchers are now finding whether socially inherited reproductive inequality exists in other species and whether female hyenas invest differently in offspring based on rank

BIG SHOT



Jack Guo, an engineer who led the development of TianGong Ultra, stands among Tiangong Ultra and Tiangong Omni humanoid robots as he poses for a photo at the Beijing Humanoid Robot Innovation Centre on September 4, 2026. At the World Humanoid Robot Games, TianGong ran 100 metres in in 8.64 seconds, almost a second faster than Usain Bolt’s world record. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Mathathon: a Caltech conflict

Vasudevan Mukunth

A new event at the California Institute of Technology, called ‘Mathathon’, pulled together by a group of undergraduate students to “promote the responsible use of AI in mathematics” quickly ran into controversy last week.

Scheduled for October 30 to November 1 this year, its first round will have 100 teams of mathematicians work on open problems in mathematics for 40 hours, with each team receiving around \$20,000 worth of tokens to use on frontier AI models. The teams that have made the most progress will enter a second round that will be six months long. According to the organisers, the event aims in part to increase the exposure of mathematicians outside AI companies to powerful models.

However, on September 10, a coalition of current and former Caltech mathematicians published an open letter, signed by over 700 of their peers, including four Fields Medal winners, asking for the Mathathon to be called off. The letter said the Mathathon’s accelerated format would encourage “slop” mathematics that other mathematicians must then spend time and effort to correct and verify. Because OpenAI and Anthropic had sponsored the event, the letter also accused AI companies of turning open mathematics problems into publicity contests while draining mathematics of its human and social resources.



A view of the Millikan Library at Caltech. CANON.VS.NIKON (CC BY-SA)

While the organisers subsequently changed some of the Mathathon’s rules, including requiring participants in the second round to publish their work as preprint papers on the arXiv repository, they refused to cancel the event. However, OpenAI withdrew as a sponsor; the website currently says Anthropic will provide \$600,000 in credits.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Building consensus

The 18th BRICS Summit pushed for changes in traditional power equations

Reaffirming the importance of reformed multilateralism in a world riven with unilateral actions by superpowers emerged as a binding theme of the 18th BRICS Summit and the New Delhi Declaration. The Summit's success could be measured by three main parameters – the participation of members at the highest levels, the importance given to intra-BRICS trade cooperation mechanisms and the consensus achieved by Indian negotiators in forging a joint statement in a time of war. The government should be commended for ensuring that Iran and the UAE, two rivals in the West Asian conflict, used the occasion for their highest-level bilateral meeting since the war began. The New Delhi Declaration, which was issued despite scepticism about all the differences within the grouping, presented the BRICS as a formidable front in its 20th year. Among the BRICS members, the position of Saudi Arabia, which has yet to formally join the group, remains ambiguous, as Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud arrived after the main session where the joint statement was adopted on Saturday. For the other members, however, the consensus was clear on issues of global importance. The declaration made a call for the reform of the Security Council and support for a greater role for Brazil and India while recommending new initiatives for global governance. It condemned western sanctions and tariffs and resolved to improve intra-BRICS trade and transact more in local currencies. It also condemned unilateral wars, without criticising any member. While the statement omitted references to the U.S.-Israel attacks on Iran, the assassination of Iran's Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, and of Iran's retaliatory attacks on its neighbours, especially the UAE, it is understood that this was due to a last-moment compromise effected between the two countries so as to forge the agreed text. It also took an exceptionally strong position on Israel's actions in Palestine and Lebanon.

India's fourth BRICS chairship has given ballast to its reputation as a Global South balancer with easy access to both sides of a divided world, while delivering bilateral benefits. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's close attention to Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian would have gone some way in assuaging hurt feelings, when New Delhi appeared to be tilting towards the U.S. and Israel in the war. Mr. Modi's meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping also afforded the two countries a chance to reaffirm their political will to normalise ties. And his meeting with important leaders from the ASEAN grouping and African nations paid much-needed attention to India's ties with them. This BRICS Summit will be remembered for a moment of solidarity among countries that have many differences but are together in desiring a shift in traditional power equations to one more driven by their emerging economies.

A rising graph

Doping is now a deep-rooted culture in Indian sports

At least 13 doping positives in the run-up to the recent Commonwealth Games and the upcoming Asian Games have again put India in an embarrassing spotlight. For a country that has been notoriously leading the global doping charts for three consecutive years, the spate of positive results across disciplines including athletics, weightlifting, wrestling, wushu and judo, has not only brought shame but has also robbed India of some berths in these prestigious events. The dope-tainted names have forced authorities to pull them out of the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games squad. More such names are expected to trickle out in the coming weeks. Lucrative cash incentives for Asian Games medalists are a major factor driving athletes and coaches to take shortcuts, risking their health and reputation, as well as the country's pride. While the spike in dope-positive results ahead of major multi-sport events is not new, the jump this time is a cause for concern. The matter getting raised during the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) workshops in Delhi, the Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU) downgrading India due to an extremely high risk of doping, and an international agency recently conducting surprise tests in Bhubaneswar and Bengaluru indicate the seriousness of the issue.

Even though National Sports Federations have been expressing concern, it cannot be said that they are strict to the core to curb the menace. Despite being seriously understaffed, the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA), which shoulders the primary anti-doping responsibility in India, has significantly increased the number of tests and raids based on intelligence gathering. But it needs to do more in a vast and populous country to discourage doping. Besides, NADA needs to get out of the government's control to function truly independently in order to enhance its effectiveness. Proper implementation of the National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act, 2025, to give more powers to NADA and its allied bodies, is another requirement. With dope testing becoming costlier and NADA needing more staff, the government can bolster the fight against doping by increasing the overall budget allocation, which was reduced in the current budget. The other challenge is to cut the supply line, as India has become a hub for the trade in banned substances sourced from different countries. An Indian serving a jail term in Kenya for illegally importing performance-enhancing drugs stands as proof of this. As India prepares for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and hopes to host the Olympics in the future, it needs to act resolutely to weed out a deep-rooted doping culture in Indian sports.

The terror attack carried out by al-Qaeda on the Twin Towers in New York on September 11, 2001 was neither the first major terrorist attack in the world nor the first against the United States. But it fundamentally changed how terrorism would be fought in the decades that followed.

Over the past 25 years, the global security landscape, including that of India, has changed irreversibly. The forms of terrorism have evolved, the instruments used to perpetrate terror have changed, and so too have the strategies adopted by countries around the world to counter terrorism.

We no longer hear of large terror groups operating under ruthless terrorist leaders such as al-Qaeda founder Osama bin Laden or Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, who led the Islamic State and called for the establishment of an Islamic Caliphate. Instead, terror groups have morphed into smaller, more autonomous entities. Lone-wolf attacks are becoming the norm, while technologies such as drones, cyber capabilities, and even artificial intelligence are being used not only by terror groups but also by nations combating terrorism.

From an Indian standpoint, 9/11 certainly helped bring greater attention to India's concerns over cross-border terrorism, particularly in Kashmir. However, it was not until the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks (November 2008) that the world truly stood in solidarity with India and acknowledged its fight against cross-border terrorism. Over the years, India's strategy towards terrorism has evolved – from a passive strategy of merely warning Pakistan but not punishing it, to a bold and active strategy that classifies any act of terrorism backed by support from across the border as an 'act of war'.

The starting years saw a passive response

Although cross-border terror commenced in Kashmir in early 1990s, the first major terror attack did not come from the Kashmir Valley. The assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi by the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam terror group of Sri Lanka on May 21, 1991 in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu shook the nation.

With no clearly defined counter-terror strategy and a rapidly expanding terror network in Kashmir, India found itself stretched. The March 1993 Mumbai serial blasts, which killed over 250 people in 13 coordinated blasts across the city, and the synchronised blasts across Coimbatore city (Tamil Nadu) in February 1998 exposed the inadequacies of India's internal security mechanisms to detect and fight terror inside the country.

However, the direct role of Pakistan was first exposed with the hijack of Indian Airlines flight IC-814, on December 24, 1999. Under tremendous public pressure and with very few options, India agreed to release dreaded Pakistan-based terrorists such as Ahmed Omar Sheikh and



Rajeew Agarwal

Retired colonel, Senior Research Consultant at CRF, Delhi and the author of the book, 'Between Tehran and Tel Aviv: Gaza's Story of Unending War'

India has moved from defensive restraint to proactive counter-terrorism

Masood Azhar in exchange for more than 160 civilian hostages. The attack on India's Parliament in New Delhi by the Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorist group on December 13, 2001 outraged India and led to a large-scale military mobilisation under 'Operation Parakram'. With India and Pakistan having acquired nuclear weapons, the threat of escalation grew, prompting the international community to rush in to cool tempers. After almost two years of a tense standoff, the military disengagement took place without any direct punishment on Pakistan. The 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks – widely considered India's 9/11 moment – also did not lead to any military action against Pakistan.

There were other terror attacks too, such as the 2002 Akshardham Temple attack, the 2006 Varanasi serial bomb blasts, and the 2010 German Bakery blast in Pune. Delhi, too, was not left untouched by terror. Even before the Parliament attack, an Army garrison within the Red Fort was targeted on December 22, 2000 by Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorists, resulting in the deaths of three soldiers. In October 2005, over 60 people were killed in serial blasts that rocked popular Delhi markets, including Sarojini Nagar and Paharganj. Again, in September 2008, months before the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, multiple blasts rocked commercial areas of Delhi, including Connaught Place, Greater Kailash, and Karol Bagh. On September 7, 2011, a briefcase bomb exploded outside the Delhi High Court, killing 15 people. The attack was claimed by Harkat-ul-Jihad Islami (HUJI), a terror group affiliated with al-Qaeda and largely based in Pakistan. In all these cases, and many others, India chose not to respond directly and decisively, even after conclusive proof of Pakistan's direct support for these attacks. How and when, then, did India change its strategy?

Taking the fight across the border

It was after a change of government at the Centre in May 2014, and its resolve not to let terror go unpunished, that India changed its strategy towards cross-border terrorism. The terror attack on September 18, 2016 by Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorists on an Army camp in Uri, Kashmir, led to the first cross-border surgical strikes (September 28-29). The strikes not only sent a strong message but also served as a clear statement of intent. Soon thereafter, following the terror attack on a Central Reserve Police Force convoy in Pulwama, Kashmir, on February 14, 2019, the Indian Air Force (IAF) launched strikes on a JeM terror camp in Balakot. This marked the first time that the IAF had crossed into Pakistani airspace to carry out a strike against a terror target.

However, it was the terror attack in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025 that outraged the nation like never before. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who was on a visit to Saudi Arabia, returned to India and soon after, the Indian armed forces

launched Operation Sindoor on May 6-7, hitting the heart of the Pakistan-based terror network. In a matter of 96 hours, the leaders and headquarters of the terror networks (LeT and JeM) were destroyed and Pakistani military assets were pulverised.

Where India stands on terror now

India has come a long way since the menace of cross-border terrorism took root in Kashmir in the early 1990s. From a passive and reactive policy, India has emerged as a leading voice in the global fight against terrorism. Soon after Operation Sindoor, India declared three clear intentions – first, that the era of restraint and patience is over, and Pakistan will have to pay a direct and heavy price for any terror attack in the future. Second, that any future act of cross-border terrorism emanating from Pakistan will be treated as an 'act of war'. Third, that Pakistani nuclear blackmail will no longer be a restraining factor.

India also unveiled 'PRAHAAR', its first comprehensive National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy, on February 23, 2026. The policy provides a national counter-terrorism framework for preventing and responding to terrorist activities and radicalisation through coordinated "whole-of-government" and "whole-of-society" approaches.

Although the number of terror-related incidents in Kashmir has declined drastically, the possibility of a few terrorists infiltrating across the Line of Control (LoC) and evading intelligence and security agencies remains. The answer lies in a four-fold strategy. First, continue to hunt down and eliminate the remnants of the terror network in the country, particularly in Kashmir. Second, take pre-emptive military action against any potential terror threat building across the LoC, including at terrorist launch pads. With years of experience and a deeply embedded intelligence network, this is possible. Third, undertake an exhaustive de-radicalisation programme across the country that not only motivates young people to join the mainstream but also makes the prospect of joining or supporting a terror outfit unattractive and prohibitively costly. Fourth, take all necessary steps to cut off terror financing, in close coordination with friendly countries.

Twenty-five years after 9/11, the threat of terrorism across the globe has not been eliminated but has instead morphed into new forms. At the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit in Bishkek on September 1, Mr. Modi called out the double standards on terrorism and said, "We must send a strong message to countries that use terrorism as an instrument of policy and provide safe haven and support to terrorists that terrorism can never be a strategic asset for anyone." At the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi, an exclusive paragraph on the Pahalgam terror attack was included in the Delhi Declaration, clearly underscoring the growing global consensus on combating terrorism.

Pakistan's westward turn — strategic depth or overstretch

The defence cooperation agreement signed by Pakistan and Kuwait on August 27, 2026, is the latest manifestation of Pakistan's rapidly expanding strategic footprint in West Asia. The agreement assumes greater significance when viewed alongside Pakistan's membership of the Saudi Arabia-Türkiye-Pakistan defence arrangement and its recent role as an intermediary between Iran and the United States.

Enduring links

Pakistan's West Asian orientation has deep historical roots. From its inception, it attempted to combine its South Asian geopolitical identity with that of a major Muslim power. During the Cold War, Pakistan, Iran and Türkiye were linked through the Central Treaty Organization (CENTO) and subsequently through the Regional Cooperation for Development.

The decisive turn towards the Arab world came after Pakistan's defeat and dismemberment in 1971. It sought to compensate for its diminished position in South Asia by emphasising its Islamic identity, symbolised by the Islamic summit held in Lahore in 1974. Pakistan simultaneously developed extensive military relationships with Saudi Arabia and the Gulf monarchies.

What is new, therefore, is not Pakistan's involvement in West Asia but its increasing institutionalisation. The Makkah Agreement of August 7 stipulated that an armed attack against one member would be regarded as an attack against all. The three countries moved quickly to give the arrangement institutional substance. At the August 31 meeting in Istanbul, their Foreign and Defence Ministers and military chiefs decided to establish a permanent secretariat in Saudi Arabia, with a Pakistani serving as its first Secretary-General for three years. They also agreed to strengthen military interoperability and pursue defence-industrial cooperation, including



Mohammed Ayoob

University Distinguished Professor Emeritus of International Relations, Michigan State University, and the author of 'From Regional Security to Global IR' (2024)

Pakistan's expanding West Asian role brings influence and opportunity, but also strategic risks

joint technology development and production.

But the new arrangement is already confronting Pakistan with the contradictions inherent in its expanding West Asian role. Renewed Houthi missile and drone attacks against Saudi Arabia created the first serious test of the Makkah pact. The Houthis' recent capture of Mocha port and Perim island have further added to their capability to choke off Saudi shipping through the Bab al-Mandab. With the Strait of Hormuz effectively closed by Iran, a frustrated Saudi Arabia may re-launch a full-fledged war against the Houthis. This could create a major dilemma for Pakistan especially if Riyadh decides to invoke the collective-defence provision of the Makkah agreement.

Pakistan wants to be Saudi Arabia's security partner, Türkiye's strategic ally, Iran's friend and interlocutor, Washington's useful intermediary, and an increasingly important security provider to the Gulf monarchies. These roles are compatible when regional tensions are manageable. They become irreconcilable when they are not.

What it means for India

For India, Pakistan's westward turn presents both a challenge and a potential relief. A Pakistan embedded in a network of West Asian security relationships may acquire defence in depth. Saudi financial resources, Turkish defence technology and Pakistan's expanding relationships with Gulf militaries can theoretically increase Islamabad's resilience in a confrontation with India. Türkiye is already Pakistan's most vocal major supporter on Kashmir. Pakistan's nuclear status also enhances its strategic value to Arab states concerned about an increasingly unstable regional order because of nuclear-armed Israel's aggressive policies.

But strategic depth can easily become strategic overstretch. Pakistan's security establishment has

historically concentrated overwhelmingly on India. A Pakistan increasingly required to devote diplomatic, military and intelligence resources to Iran, Saudi Arabia, the Gulf, Yemen and the Red Sea may have fewer resources to concentrate on India.

The current Saudi-Houthi confrontation and the distinct possibility of it spawning a war clearly demonstrate the danger of Pakistan's strategic overstretch. The deeper Pakistan becomes embedded in West Asian security arrangements, the harder it will become to remain aloof from the region's conflicts. If the Houthi-Saudi confrontation escalates, Islamabad may eventually have to choose between honouring the credibility of its collective-defence commitments and maintaining its carefully cultivated relationship with Tehran, the Houthis' principal ally.

India should therefore resist interpreting Pakistan's growing West Asian role in purely negative terms. Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and the other Gulf states have major economic and strategic relationships with India that they are unlikely to sacrifice for Pakistan. New Delhi should continue deepening these relationships as a counter to Pakistan's expanding footprint in West Asia.

The consolidation of Pakistan's West Asian relationships undoubtedly provides it with greater strategic depth *vis-à-vis* India. But those very relationships expose it to some of the world's most combustible rivalries. For India, therefore, Pakistan's westward turn contains a paradox. A Pakistan more deeply embedded in a West Asian security structure may in theory look strategically stronger. But a Pakistan entangled in mutually contradictory West Asian commitments will soon discover that it could be indefinitely stuck in a quagmire of its own choosing. It is far more difficult to get off the tiger than to get on it.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India's BRICS moment

The high-profile 18th BRICS Summit could not have come at a more opportune time, with the United States flexing its muscles, adopting a belligerent, obstinate and defiant stand across a raft of issues, and treating a galaxy of countries across the world with disdain and contempt (Front page,

September 13). The successful summit is, undeniably, a testament to India's steadfast commitment and desire to usher in an era of durable peace, stability and security in the world. One positive aspect was the interaction between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping, which,

it is hoped, will pave the way for a ratcheting up of relations between the two countries, which are currently far from rosy. Whether the outcome of the Summit will lead to an enhanced level of cooperation and coordination among the participating nations across a plethora of spheres, and

whether it will have an impact on Washington's style of functioning, only the days ahead will reveal.
V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

Statesmanship vs theatre

The dignified response by DMK president M.K. Stalin to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's recent

visual gesture in the Assembly serves as a profound lesson in political maturity. Mr. Stalin's injury should not have been a punchline or a subject for mimicry; it was a physical scar from 1976. By choosing to offer statesmanship and constructive advice, Mr. Stalin held up a mirror to the current administration.

True leadership is earned through decades of public struggle and administrative execution, not through social media reels or theatrical swipes meant to mask governance deficits.
R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Revisiting Kuwait’s invasion amid war

As the world witnesses yet another war in West Asia, the passage of August revives the haunting memory of Iraqi troops invading Kuwait on August 2, 1990. As Kuwait remembers that sordid day, another story, which has largely been forgotten, also needs to be remembered – the story of the migrant workers. For them, the war was not an abstract international crisis; it meant unemployment and the loss of everything they had built abroad.

The labourers and domestic workers were the most hit, being abandoned when employers fled. Many returned empty-handed, leaving behind wages, savings, and possessions. And while some chose to undertake the arduous return journey, others had no choice but to stay back.

There were also cases of employers utilising the war as a pretext to withhold dues. While a UN Compensation Commission was set up to retrieve wages, it was fruitful in compensating only white-collar workers and high-skilled blue-collar workers while labourers, domestic workers and other low-skilled workers lost all their hard-earned wages. This is the same story that unfolded decades later during the COVID-19 crisis which triggered the Justice for Wage Theft Campaign.

However, because of their dire circumstances, when the war ended, migrants went back to the same jobs and in many cases to the same employers, proving that the Gulf Dream was only a mirage for many.

After the invasion, some undertook extraordinary journeys to return home;



Ginu Zacharia Oommen

Chairperson of the Kerala State Food Commission, and visiting professor at International Institute for Migration and Development



Anu Abraham

Research Affiliate, PRIO Migration Centre, Peace Research Institute Oslo

The legacy of the invasion extended well beyond 1991, with the war reshaping not only migration strategies but also the social geography of the Malayali diaspora in Kuwait

some of them travelled via roads in cars, crossing many international borders over days, and were able to reach Keralam through informal networks of assistance. Many others were evacuated via civilian-led airlifts, made possible by the efforts of diaspora leaders.

However, some stayed back in the war rather than returning home to debt, and adapted in remarkable ways. One of our respondents who had then just opened an electrical shop, remained in Kuwait, taking on odd jobs; he sheltered quite a few fellow migrants and was briefly detained by Iraqi soldiers. When the war ended, he reopened his shop under skies darkened by burning oil wells, hoping for a brighter future. A tailor, who was stranded after his employer disappeared without paying his wages, survived through casual labour, and sheltered in basements during the war.

Community as resilience

The invasion also saw stories of resilience and courage. When Kuwait was occupied by Iraq, the Indian embassy could not continue its operations and was formally withdrawn and the staff relocated to Basra. One of the migrants recalls how a voluntary committee of Indian businessmen assumed critical roles, coordinating evacuations, liaising with officials in Basra, and arranging buses, ships, and flights to ensure that migrants were not left to fend for themselves. In an extraordinary move, they were entrusted to issue travel documents using official seals.

Despite logistical hurdles and long desert waits, these leaders were able to

evacuate 1,70,000 Indians – an exceptional instance of diaspora-led crisis management in the absence of state infrastructure and embassy guidance.

Another striking manifestation of the war was the contrasting response of migrants after returning to Keralam. In south Keralam, large public rallies expressed support for the Emir of Kuwait, while in north Keralam, especially Kozhikode, massive demonstrations backed the Iraqi leadership.

The legacy of the invasion extended well beyond 1991, with the war reshaping not only migration strategies but also the social geography of the Malayali diaspora in Kuwait. A lingering sense of insecurity took hold, with workers beginning to save more aggressively; transferring money home quickly; and investing in land and houses back home. The social geography of Kuwait also changed. Migrants from Keralam who were never ghettoised, started clustering in neighbourhoods such as Abbasiya – “mini-Kerala” – creating tightly knit communities, with community and religious organisations assuming more importance. This offered emotional support and a sense of stability to the migrants. Thus, the war not only reshaped individual lives but the collective outlook of migrant groups across the Gulf.

As war once again unsettles West Asia, these memories acquire renewed relevance. Migrant workers continue to build the economies of the Gulf while remaining among those least protected when conflict erupts.

The evidence gap in dole politics

In May 1795, English magistrates met at the Pelican Inn in Speenhamland, Berkshire. With food prices rising and the French Revolution unsettling the English establishment, they decided to top up agricultural wages from parish funds, linking payouts to bread prices and family size. Hungarian economic historian Karl Polanyi later saw this as an early assertion of a human “right to live” against the harshness of the market.

Critics, however, held a different view. Once wage support, relief for the poor, and public finance were folded into one instrument, it became unclear what the system was protecting: poor families, the wage structure, employers, or social peace. By subsidising wages from public funds, the Speenhamland system blurred price signals and weakened incentives. While relief could be justified, the instrument still had to be judged by its effects. India’s dole politics must now face the same test.

Cash support can indeed be essential in a poor, informal economy. The Economic Survey 2025-26 notes that transfers to women amount to 11-24% of the monthly income of women daily-wage workers, and 11-87% of self-employed women. But a transfer that begins as relief can also become a permanent fiscal commitment unless there is a clear account of who receives it, what it changes, and what it displaces.

These concerns assume importance because dole politics is now a regular feature of Indian statecraft. It appears as free electricity, free bus travel, monthly cash transfers, subsidised



Sayantan Kundu

Assistant Professor of Finance at IMI Kolkata. Views are personal



Amarendu Nandy

Associate Professor of Economics & Public Policy at IIM Ranchi. Views are personal

food, and utility subsidies. PRS Legislative Research estimates that unconditional cash transfers to women alone rose from two States in 2022-23 to 12 states in 2025-26, with an estimated annual cost of ₹1.68 lakh crore (about 0.5% of GDP). For example, West Bengal has moved from Lakshmir Bhandar to Annapurna Yojana, budgeting ₹36,000 crore for a ₹3,000 monthly transfer to about 1.3 crore women. Tamil Nadu allocated ₹14,412 crore for the Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thogai in its 2026-27 interim budget, and Assam set aside ₹5,000 crore for Orunodoi. Such schemes stake major claims on State finances.

Need for accountability

Cash may improve welfare, but it should not become a substitute for the public goods that make welfare durable. The same woman who values ₹1,500-₹3,000 may also need a functioning health centre, childcare, a good government school, or access to better work. A cash transfer may soften the strain created by weak institutions, but it cannot, by itself, address them.

Governments often attach lofty social purposes such as dignity and empowerment to these transfers, but rarely publish the model that links payments to outcomes. Who exactly is being targeted? What baseline data justifies the scheme? What effect is anticipated on consumption, debt, nutrition, schooling, health spending, labour supply, or women’s bargaining power? Without such answers, it is unsurprising that much of India’s dole politics today is defended by the moral language of welfare rather

than evidence. An ADB study, prepared for the 16th Finance Commission, found that India lacks a systematic dataset of government expenditure on cash-transfer schemes.

Other democracies also redistribute and are not immune to welfare politics. However, benefits such as unemployment insurance, food support, and healthcare subsidies are usually tied to eligibility rules, contribution records, job-search obligations, or periodic reassessment. India need not copy these systems mechanically. Some transfers, especially to women in poor households, may be better left unconditional. But the fewer the conditions placed, the greater must be the obligation on governments to provide evidence.

A large recurring transfer should therefore include a welfare impact statement before rollout, detailing the objective, eligibility rule, expected coverage, five-year fiscal cost, alternatives considered, likely leakage and exclusion errors, and measurable outcomes. After rollout, household surveys should record not only whether the transfer was received but also how it affected consumption, debt, health spending, schooling, mobility, work incentives, control over household expenditure, and subjective well-being. Anonymised microdata should then be made available for independent research. Schemes that spend public money on this scale must survive severe scrutiny.

The case for evidence is also one of democratic fairness. Evidence will not remove politics from welfare, but it could make that politics more honest.

SIR: Glaring oddities in Maharashtra’s deletion patterns

A total of 2.07 crore names have been deleted from Maharashtra’s electoral rolls; the figure is higher than Chhattisgarh’s entire electorate

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A. Nitika Francis

Analyses of constituency-wise deletions and lists of deletions in Maharashtra after the enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls have revealed several oddities, indicating high chances of aggressive and arbitrary deletions. The draft SIR roll released on August 31, showed that a total of 2.07 crore electors have been dropped from the 288 Assembly Constituencies (ACs) of Maharashtra, which is 21.14% of the 9.79 crore electors whose names were there on the pre-SIR rolls.

To place Maharashtra’s deletions in context, the 2.07 crore names dropped is higher than Chhattisgarh’s entire electorate. More surprisingly, it is higher than even the 2.04 crore deletions in Uttar Pradesh, during the SIR; U.P. is India’s largest State with 13.4 crore electors – which is bigger than the number of electors in the draft rolls of Maharashtra, Karnataka and Delhi combined.

The Election Commission of India (EC) has desisted from releasing the Elector to Population (EP) ratio for any State during the ongoing SIR process despite its own Manual on Electoral Rolls mandating it to do so during and after every revision. An estimate of EP ratio based on the projected population in the 18-plus age-group as per the report of Government of India’s Technical Group on Population Projections showed that Maharashtra’s draft rolls are short of 1.92 crore electors, which is roughly the same as the number of deletions (**Table 1**).

As seen in other States, deletions in Maharashtra were also highly concentrated in urban areas (**MAP 1**). A total of 58 ACs saw at least one-third of names (33%) in the rolls getting deleted, of which 25 ACs saw deletions of 40% or

more. Almost all of these were in and around the Mumbai, Pune, Thane and Nashik districts. Bhiwandi East in Thane recorded the highest deletions (49.1%). Of the 3.76 lakh voters, 1.85 lakh names were deleted.

“Permanently Shifted” and “Untraceable or Absent” seem to have been used as blanket categories to delete large number of names from the rolls. **Table 2** shows a sample of a few constituencies that saw deletions due to widely different reasons. Kalyan Rural in Thane saw 2.52 lakh deletions, of which 2.39 lakh (96.5%) were marked as shifted or absent – that is 96-97 in every 100 deleted voters had either shifted or were untraceable, as per the EC. But the constituency saw only 4,882 deletions marked as ‘Deceased’.

In 85 ACs, shifted and absent accounted for anywhere between 75% to 96.5% of all deletions. These 85 had 3.21 crore electors before SIR, of which 1.17 crore (36.3%) were deleted. Of these 1.17 crore deletions, 97.9 lakh (84%) were marked as shifted or absent.

The Hindu had pointed out how the EC’s own manual says that an absentee voter cannot be deleted from the rolls as they continued to be an ordinary resident of the place where they are enrolled. An FAQ published by the Chief Electoral Officer of Maharashtra says ‘Absent’ means “the elector was unavailable”. Analysis indicated that these two reasons were applied arbitrarily and interchangeably in several constituencies.

Table 3 shows the top five districts that saw extreme variations in the per cent of electors deleted for being absent. Pune exemplified this problem, as shown in **Chart 1**. Within the same district and among ACs located nearby, the share of electors marked as shifted or absent widely varied. Maval saw just 322 names (0.4%) marked as Absent while over 77,000 were marked as shifted. Hadapsar, on the other hand, saw 86% of its 2.98 lakh voters marked as absent.

Counting out en masse

The data were sourced from the Election Commission of India. Night-time light intensity from the Socio-economic High-resolution Rural-Urban Geographic Platform for India (SHRUG) database maintained by the Development Data Lab, drawn from satellite readings from the year 2023 was used to classify constituencies as urban or rural.

TABLE 1: An estimate of Elector-to-Population ratio shows that the draft SIR roll is short of roughly the same number of electors deleted during the enumeration phase

Metric	Value
Electors before SIR	9,78,54,049
Deletions	2,06,88,487
Electors in draft SIR rolls	7,71,65,562 (-21.14%)
Projected voter population	9,65,00,000
Shortfall	-19,334,438 (-20%)
ACs with >33% deletions	58
ACs with >40% deletions	25

Deletion of **2.07 crore** names in Maharashtra is higher than deletions in U.P.’s final SIR rolls

About **75%** of all deletions happened in the 147 constituencies that are highly or moderately urban



Double check: Booth Level Officers sort enumeration forms as voter enumeration drive commences in Nagpur. ANI

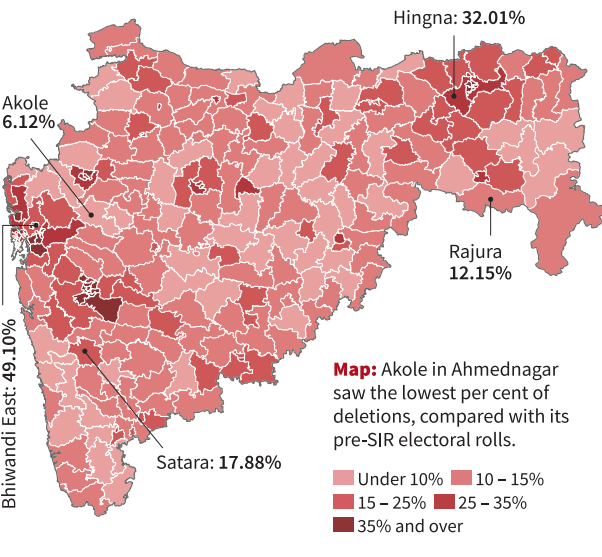


TABLE 3: The top five districts that saw extreme variations in the per cent of electors being deleted for being ‘Absent’

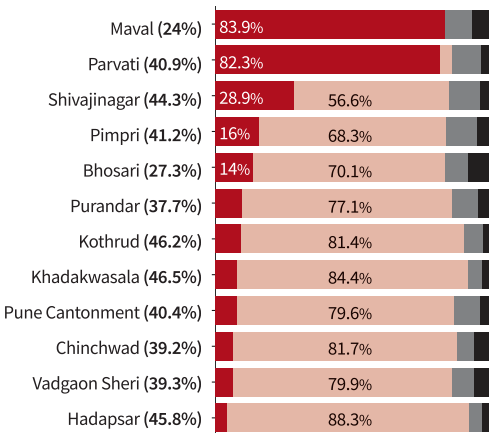
District	No of ACs	How widely did % of deletions marked as ‘Absent’ vary? Min → Max
Palghar	6	3.3 → 85.5%
Pune	21	0.4 → 88.3%
Nashik	15	8.1 → 86.5%
Aurangabad	9	7.3 → 67.3%
Nagpur	12	4.4 → 59.7%

Wide variations were observed in constituencies within districts that are largely of similar urban or rural character. In the 15 constituencies in Nashik, electors deleted for being ‘Absent’ varied from **8.1 to 86.5%**

TABLE 2: A few constituencies that indicate widely different and non-uniform application of reasons for deletions

Assembly (District)	Pre-SIR electors	Deletions (%)	Why is it odd?
Kalyan Rural (Thane)	5.48 lakh	2,52,247 (46%)	Only 1.9% marked as Deceased, the lowest in the State
Shrigonda (Ahmednagar)	3.48 lakh	40,110 (11.5%)	Nearly 45% marked as Deceased, highest in the State
Solapur South (Solapur)	3.98 lakh	64,326 (16.2%)	Nearly 25% were Duplicates
Worli (Mumbai City)	2.68 lakh	1,05,575 (39.4%)	Only 1.3% (3,786) were Duplicates

CHART 1: Variations in the use of ‘Shifted’ vs ‘Absent’ within Pune’s ACs. Values (%) in brackets are deletions in the ACs



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 14, 1976

Himalaya seminar may help quake forecasts

New Delhi, September 13: Mr. Chandrajit Yadav, Union Minister for Steel and Mines while inaugurating the five-day international seminar on Himalayan Geology which commenced here to-day, expressed the hope that the deliberations at the seminar would lead to some ‘dependable clues’ for the prediction of earthquakes for future lines of action.

Stressing the importance of earthquake prediction and the science of seismology for an agricultural country in India where a large number of irrigation projects has to be built to harness its available water resources, the Minister said “recent earthquakes in some parts of Asia are reminder to us that at least in India very little has been done in the way of predicting earthquakes. Some of the countries have made remarkable progress in this direction and can save humanity by sharing their knowledge. The world community of scientists has to work collectively. These calamities do not respect national boundaries.”

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 14, 1926

Encouraging British films in India

London, September 13: In connection with the British film scheme mentioned in the message of the 11th September, it is stated that the six Indian rulers mentioned already have contributed quarter a million sterling in money, land and buildings.

Maharaja of Alwar has offered £100,000 and free sites for cinema in India.

The Maharaja of Patiala has offered £30,000 H.H. the Aga Khan £35,000 to £40,000.

The remaining princes have not yet decided on the cash offers but will supply sites and are in some cases building cinemas.

It is hoped that by the middle of 1927 there will be a chain of 300 cinemas across India showing films from Britain and from Dominions in the proportion of 6 British films for one screened in other parts of the Empire.

Mr. Nirranjan Pal states that the Princes do not expect any reward for their munificence.

The profits will go to a trust or endowment fund for the development of films in India.

THE HINDU

6.94 in lakh tonnes. India will get country-specific tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) totalling 1.64 million tonnes annually for exporting steel products to the European Union, of which 6,94,853 tonnes will be under the free trade agreement, according to the draft text of the pact released by the EU. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

CMYK

CACHE



There is no steering wheel inside the Cybercab, raising questions about passenger safety. REUTERS

Why Tesla’s steering-less Cybercab is under investigation

Tesla has rolled out its two-seater Cybercab robotaxis in limited areas of Austin; while supporters see robotaxis as safer and more accessible, Tesla's Cybercabs face regulatory scrutiny and wider concerns over how driverless vehicles respond to emergencies and unexpected road situations

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:
On September 3, Tesla announced the rollout of its new electric robotaxis, offering services in designated parts of Austin, Texas. According to news reports, the self-driving cars are almost impossible to ignore as their gold exterior and ‘Cybercab’ branding catch the eye. But the near-empty interior has sparked questions about the safety of passengers and their ability to intervene in case of emergencies.

What are the features of Tesla’s Cybercab?
The Cybercab is a self-driving car that has seating for two people. The ‘butterfly’ doors open upwards and the body boasts a sleek, cyberpunk-inspired design that contrasts sharply with the chunkier camera-mounted cars from rival Waymo. The golden exterior is meant to represent a “literal” golden age of transportation, according to Tesla CEO Elon Musk.
There are no steering controls or pedals inside the Cybercabs. Mr. Musk has declared that the cars were built for “maximally efficient autonomous operation.” On the absence of brake pedals, he said this would help in reducing the complexity of a hydraulic system, and that “plumbing” would not have to be routed all around the car. Regulators will need to confirm if Mr. Musk’s design choices comply with their safety requirements.
Mr. Musk described the Cybercab as

“basically a super comfortable lounge on wheels with a great TV and epic sound”. With upcoming Starlink integration, users would be able to watch 4 K live video while riding in the Cybercab, he said.
Switches under the touchscreen allow users to lower the windows. A cabin camera monitors the vehicle’s interior.
A Tesla Cybercab promotional video showed passengers sleeping, watching movies, playing games, teaching children, holding dogs, and handling conference calls while they were taking a ride.
A major perk for loyal passengers is that their climate and media settings are saved in a profile and will apply to new rides as well.
Children under the age of 13 are not permitted to ride in a Cybercab vehicle.
Passengers can stop a ride by either pressing a ‘Pull Over’ button on the touchscreen or a ‘STOP’ button overhead for non-emergency situations. In the event of an emergency, users will be able to pull the door lever to trigger an emergency mechanical release. The Cybercab is designed to also pull over instead of instantly braking, based on its surroundings. Passengers can reach Tesla representatives through the car’s communication system.

Have regulators approved the Tesla Cybercabs?
While the U.S. National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA) is the regulator that enforces vehicle performance standards across the country, car makers have the option to self-certify their offerings.

The NHTSA confirmed it has opened an investigation into Tesla’s Cybercab self-certification to see if it meets the applicable Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards (FMVSS).
“When certified vehicles appear to not adhere to these requirements, NHTSA conducts an investigation,” stated the regulator.
The NHTSA explained that existing standards would remain in force even as the agency reviews rules related to standards for brake pedals, windshield wipers, lighting, and rearview mirrors, to enhance American innovation in automated vehicles.
The NHTSA is currently evaluating the Tesla Full Self-Driving (FSD) feature that is built into over three million vehicles. The assessment is related to impaired camera functions that have allegedly caused accidents in poor weather conditions.
In July, the NHTSA issued a more general warning about driverless automated vehicles “interfering,” as it noted that the cars drove into emergency scenes, blocked the way of ambulances and fire rescue vehicles, and were unable to respond properly when detecting flashing lights, fire, and traffic cones.
“This is unacceptable. To state it bluntly: an AV [automated vehicle] that cannot safely interact with first responders is a danger to the general public,” stated the NHTSA’s letter.
Cybercabs are not the first robotaxis launched by Tesla. The EV maker has already deployed its Model Y cars in Tampa and Miami, in Florida, and Austin, Dallas, and Houston, in Texas. Cybercabs

are currently available in limited areas only in Austin.

What are some concerns surrounding robotaxis?
Robotaxis or self-driving taxis have been hailed for a variety of reasons. They are often viewed as a safer option for female passengers, people who cannot communicate verbally, or passengers in vulnerable situations.
Supporters of robotaxis claim that they help lower accident rates (when compared to human-operated cars), prevent rash/fatigued/drunken driving, and that the AI systems supporting these cars are rapidly advancing.
Robotaxis have also been pitched as a win for accessibility and inclusion, as some customers complained that human-operated cabs cancel rides when passengers disclose disabilities, health conditions, and the use of wheelchairs or service animals. In fact, Tesla’s own Cybercab ad showed users of wheelchairs and crutches being able to store their belongings in the car boot. (This ad, however, did not cover how a non-mobile user would be able to make their way unassisted into the driverless car without their mobility aid.)
Still, robotaxis can pose safety risks when facing unexpected circumstances. Videos and posts shared on social media have recorded instances of driverless taxis being unable to move when held up by men blocking their path, leaving passengers fearful inside. Minor crashes and intrusions into protected areas have also been documented.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Questions on the much venerated and loved elephant-headed God on the occasion of Ganesha Chathurthi

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**
According to the Padma Purana, how did Ganesha get his elephant head?
- QUESTION 2**
Because of what distinct features is Ganesha also called Lambodhara and Vakratunda?
- QUESTION 3**
In which form and which sage’s ‘kamandalu’ did Ganesha knock over to let Kaveri flow to the southern parts of India?
- QUESTION 4**
According to many accounts, Ganesha has two wives. Name them.
- QUESTION 5**
What is special about the idol of Ganesha

- located within the Muktheeswarar Temple complex in Thilatharpanapuri, Tamil Nadu?
- QUESTION 6**
Once, the Chandra (moon) laughed at Ganesha for falling after struggling with his pot belly. Initially, Ganesha cursed the moon to become invisible but later revoked the curse, partially resulting in which feature of the moon?
- QUESTION 7**
One version of how Ganesha lost a part of a tusk is because of a duel with which avatar of Vishnu?
- QUESTION 8**
According to the Ganesha Purana, Krauncha has become an integral part of the Ganesha myth. How?



Visual Question:
Identify this person and his single biggest contribution to modern-day worship of Ganesha. WIKIPEDIA COMMONS

- Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:**
1. Which two Scottish commanders jointly led the forces at Stirling Bridge? **Ans: William Wallace and Andrew de Moray**
2. How many horsemen could reportedly cross the bridge abreast? **Ans: Two**
3. What type of Scottish formation played a crucial role in repelling the English cavalry? **Ans: Spearmen organised in schiltron formations**
4. Which English knight famously managed to fight his way back across the bridge after the Scottish attack? **Ans: Sir Marmaduke Thweng**
5. According to the contemporary English chronicler Walter of Guisborough, approximately how many English infantry and cavalry were killed? **Ans: About 5,000 infantry and 100 cavalry. The figure is considered an overestimate by historians**
- Visual: Identify the actor in this scene from the famous 1995 film *Braveheart*, which depicts the life of William Wallace and the Battle of Stirling Bridge. **Ans: Mel Gibson**
- Early Birds:** Saniya | Abhijeet | Sadhan Panda | Jeelani Shaik | Sitaram Saharay



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The charming grifter fooled everyone

She remained impervious to criticism

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of ‘grifter’? (S. Geetha, Visakhapatnam)
The word ‘grift’ rhymes with ‘lift’, ‘sift’ and ‘gift’. Some of us in India became aware of this word when the media in the U.S. and U.K. reported that the CEO of a well-known company referred to Meghan Markle and her husband, Prince Harry, as ‘grifters’. This slang term is mostly used in informal contexts to show disapproval. When you refer to someone as being a ‘grifter’, what you are suggesting is that the individual, though charming, is not to be trusted, for he is a swindler. This clever individual will find a way to trick you out of your money without any threat of violence. Other terms used to refer to such an individual are: con artist, scammer, swindler, defrauder, etc. One of the theories about the word is that it is derived from ‘grafter’, meaning a corrupt individual.
The novel is about two grifters and their various scams.

How is the word impervious pronounced? What does it mean? (K. Arvind, Bengaluru)
The word consists of four syllables; the first is pronounced like the ‘im’ in ‘impossible’ and ‘important’. The following ‘er’ is like the ‘er’ in ‘stern’, ‘germ’ and ‘term’, while the ‘i’ sounds like the ‘i’ in ‘bit’, ‘hit’ and ‘sit’. The final ‘ou’ is like the ‘a’ in ‘china’. The word is pronounced ‘im-PER-vi-es’ with the stress on the second syllable. It comes from the Latin ‘impervius’, and it has been part of the English language since the mid 17th century. In Latin, ‘im’ means ‘not’ and ‘pervius’ means ‘passable’. The word ‘impervious’ literally means ‘not allowing anything to pass through’. An impervious surface, for example, is one that cannot be penetrated. During the monsoon season, some of us wear a raincoat because the material used to make the coat prevents water from seeping through; it is impervious to water. Similarly, we have material impervious to heat, while some are impervious to light. It is important to note that ‘impervious’ is usually followed by ‘to’ - one is always ‘impervious to’ something.
The new vest that the soldiers are wearing is impervious to bullets.
The tiles used on the space shuttle are impervious to extreme heat.
The word ‘impervious’ can be used figuratively in everyday contexts as well. When you say that an individual is impervious to criticism, what you are suggesting is that he is not affected by it; he is not bothered or influenced by what you or others say. Criticism bounces off him very much like raindrops off a raincoat.
Jain was impervious to my jokes. I just couldn’t make him laugh.

Which is correct? ‘Log in to’ an account or ‘Log into’ an account? (M Sridhar, Pune)
I don’t think it really matters nowadays - most people accept both. Native speakers of English seem to be happy with ‘log in to’ and ‘log into’. Purists, however, would argue that it should be ‘log in to’ and not ‘log into’ because according to them, ‘log in’ is a phrasal verb.
I couldn’t log in to my new account.
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Ameliorate:
to make something better that was bad or not good enough

Synonyms: improve, enhance, help, enrich, refine

Usage: *The government hopes the scheme will ameliorate the impact of rising prices.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/ameliorate

International Phonetic Alphabet: /əˈmiːliəreɪt/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

A great innings from Viveks ends at 60



Personal touch: Viveks would have a passbook for each customer, and all records were in paper form. BIJOY GHOSH

Shiv Shivakumar

My divisional salesman in Hindustan Lever (as HUL was then called), T. Srikrishnaiah, introduced me to Viveks. Srikrishnaiah and his family had been shopping with the Chennai-headquartered consumer durables retail chain for more than 20 years and he was a great fan of it. I met B.A. Kodandarama Setty, the patriarch of Viveks. Even though I was in the FMCG sector, I wanted to meet him because I had heard so much about Viveks from everyone in Chennai retail. I was not disappointed. I was impressed with Viveks in all my interactions with them. Knowing your customer is the cornerstone of all great retailers. Viveks was way ahead of its time in consumer innovations. It understood the middle class and the bottom of the pyramid better than most others, and introduced the hire-purchase scheme and the chit 11 plus 1 (which all jewellers use today) in 1965. Viveks would have a passbook for each customer, and all its records were in paper form, which was phenomenal. All retailers like to lock in their consumers, and Viveks was the best at it. All great retailers have friendly, helpful staff; Viveks had people who were with it for decades. On a Pongal day, I went to the Viveks outlet in the city's T Nagar area at 7 am and found all the employees were in, gearing up for the big sale day. When the doors opened, many of the employees were greeting regular consumers like family. I have rarely seen that camaraderie in retail formats. Retailers need trust and Viveks had plenty of that. People rarely questioned the prices at Viveks, unlike in almost every other retail outlet. The value proposition at Viveks was built around this trust derived from years of hire-purchase schemes. Most big retailers in India tend to treat brands as vendors. I dealt with Viveks during my Nokia days, and they were always respectful of brands and realised the importance of having good brands, merchandised well in their outlets. They would insist that we train their frontline salespeople in the features and benefits of our models. I tried my best to convince them to take a big bet on mobiles, but like all big box retailers they were a bit conservative. I wish they had pivoted to mobiles quickly; they would have been a force to reckon with. Many saw Viveks as conservative and they may well be right. Viveks was frugal with inventory and never used price as a lever. What lessons does Viveks' closing have for other retailers? Online is here to stay and is a faceless disruptive force. Retail brands need to differentiate on service and experience. Retailers need to take a unified view of online and offline. E-commerce is the best price comparison channel and hence "why buy from me?" is an existential daily question for retailers. Retail brands need to manage their consumer base in a proactive manner. Family firms need clarity on how to move forward, how to pivot despite the pulls and pressures of different family factions. (Shiv Shivakumar had a long stint in Hindustan Lever before becoming MD - India of Nokia and, later, Pepsico India CEO)

Calcutta Stock Exchange's relisting bid

The planned revival of the 118-year-old exchange, where trading remains frozen since 2013, seeks to challenge Mumbai's monopoly and position Kolkata as a major capital markets hub for eastern and north-eastern India. But it must convince a sceptical SEBI and rewrite regional trading rules

NEWS ANALYSIS

Mithun Dasgupta

In an era dominated by the NSE and BSE, the revival of India's second oldest bourse appears an uphill task India's second-oldest bourse is attempting an audacious comeback from the brink of liquidation. After applying for a voluntary exit in February 2025, the Calcutta Stock Exchange (CSE) has abruptly pressed 'pause', triggered by a budget proposal from West Bengal's newly elected Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government. The State's planned revival of the 118-year-old exchange – where trading remains frozen since 2013 – seeks to challenge Mumbai's monopoly and position Kolkata as a major capital markets hub for eastern and north-eastern India. But first it must convince a sceptical Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) – the capital market regulator, and rewrite the rules of regional trading. Can a regional exchange survive in an era dominated by the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE)? How does the city's financial community view this development?

All for it Chartered accountant Binay Kumar Agarwal, who was a broker with CSE since 1996, says a new business model can create a "vibrant" exchange. "If the country can create power, bond, and carbon exchange platforms, we can



Break time: After applying for a voluntary exit in Feb. 2025, CSE has abruptly pressed pause. FILE PHOTO

also build a new model to revive CSE," he says. Many brokers share his view that the "double-engine" government – namely BJP-led Centre and State – may infuse new life into the exchange. Following the demutualisation scheme enforced by SEBI in 2007, brokers' shareholding in CSE stands at around 49%, while around 51% of the equity shares are held by corporate shareholders (non-trading members). Within the corporate shareholding segment, the BSE and the West Bengal Infrastructure Development Finance Corporation (WBIDFC) hold 4.99% and 3.38%, respectively. The city's industrialists and its small and medium businesses are enthusiastic about the revival plan. "The Calcutta Stock Exchange is an enduring symbol of India's financial heritage and Kolkata's historic leadership as a centre of commerce and enterprise. Its proposed revival is an encouraging step towards



Revival of CSE is certainly possible, but it will be operationally demanding and commercially challenging

DAMANI JUNEJA Partner-IPO Advisory and Financial Reporting, Nangia Global

strengthening eastern India's capital market ecosystem, widening access to capital, and creating new opportunities for businesses and investors alike. We look forward to seeing this proud institution reclaim its place in India's growth story," says Aditya Vardhan Agarwal, Director, Emami Group. Mamta Binani, president of MSME Development Forum (West Bengal and North-East), says the CSE's revival can foster entrepreneurship, especially among women, by providing the region's micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) a platform

to raise capital at a lower cost and gain a competitive edge. MSMEs would be able to nurture themselves better as they will only need to compete with companies in the east, rather than a bigger pool country-wide, she adds. Certainly there are advantages, as pointed out by West Bengal Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta in his Budget speech: "The revival of the Calcutta Stock Exchange would have multifarious advantages, including easier access to capital for eastern India, lower costs of listing and trading, and create new jobs."

Route to revival But revival is easier said than done. There is no policy currently for the reopening of a regional stock exchange. CSE must wait for SEBI's nod, which would depend on a credible revival plan. B. Madhav Reddy, former managing director and CEO of CSE, sees it as a for-

midable challenge. With all employees removed, existing arrangements with the NSE and BSE ended, and most of the major listed companies migrating to the bigger national exchanges, CSE must rebuild its institutional and operational capabilities from the ground up. According to Mr. Reddy, the immediate priority is to build a dedicated team capable of developing a credible business model for the exchange. "Reconstituting and broadening the board, inducting professionals with relevant market and technology expertise, and securing the confidence and support of existing shareholders would be critical first steps," he says. One potential route to revival, he suggests, would be a strategic partnership or merger with the Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India (MSE), formerly the Multi Commodity Exchange-Stock Exchange (MCX-SX), given its presence in western India. "Such a partnership could provide CSE with access to infrastructure, technology and market expertise while creating a meaningful east-west financial-market linkage between Kolkata and Mumbai," he says.

True test "The revival of the Calcutta Stock Exchange is certainly possible, but it will be both operationally demanding and commercially challenging. While regulatory approval from SEBI is an important milestone, the true test will be in rebuilding liquidity and creating a

sustainable ecosystem that attracts brokers, investors and issuers," says Damani Juneja, Partner-IPO Advisory and Financial Reporting, Nangia Global. History shows that bourses succeed only by consistently attracting trading activity. "Today, the NSE and BSE collectively account for virtually the entire equity trading ecosystem in India. Even if CSE resumes operations, persuading investors, traders and institutions to route orders through another exchange will be extremely difficult without existing liquidity," Mr. Juneja points out. Moreover, the CSE would need to establish a clearing and settlement mechanism compliant with SEBI's current regulatory framework, either on its own or through strategic partnerships. Reliable post-trade infrastructure is fundamental to market integrity. Also, substantial and ongoing investments are essential to maintaining market confidence. "Any meaningful revival would require alignment among CSE's diverse stakeholders on governance, capital infusion and long-term strategic direction," Juneja adds. Despite the challenges, several factors could work in CSE's favour: strong government support, potential to emerge as the capital market hub for eastern and north-eastern India, and a differentiated focus on regional enterprises. But the ultimate test would be in turning political willpower into daily market momentum. (The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Glittering IPOs: Jewellers tap investor appetite

Madhu Balaji

Dalal Street is experiencing a glittering gold rush as India's \$85 billion (₹7.3 lakh crore) jewellery market, long dominated by family-run shops, is formalising at breakneck speed. Driven by skyrocketing bullion prices and a consumer shift toward trusted brands, a staggering 12 mainboard and nine SME jewellery players have gone public since FY24 to fund ambitious expansion plans. The sector is expected to balloon to \$130 billion by 2030, yet the initial public offering (IPO) frenzy unfolds at a precarious crossroads. While record-high gold prices are artificially inflating revenues,

actual physical demand is shrinking. As Prithviraj Kothari, Managing Director at RiddiSiddhi Bullions and President of the India Bullion and Jewellers Association Ltd. (IBJA), points out, steep gold prices are hurting jewellery sales volume, even as sales value keeps rising. According to V.K. Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, the rising gold price and the formalisation of the hitherto unorganised industry are the primary factors behind the IPO rush. The enthusiastic response to the earlier public offers is also spurring more players to join in, he adds. But the surge in listings at a time of weakened jewel-

The growing jewellery market forms the backdrop for the rush of listings

lery buying raises questions. Will the headline revenue growth alone translate into sustainable expansion and long-term shareholder returns? C.A. Surendra Mehta, National Secretary, IBJA, explains how the lack of formalisation impacted the industry in the past. "Even banks were not giving industry status to jewellers. Now jewellers are becoming organised and compliant, and they are eligible to go for IPOs," he says. Ris-

ing gold and silver prices have necessitated more capital to run and expand jewellery businesses, he adds. Additionally, jewellers are setting up their own manufacturing facilities instead of relying on small job workers. GST accelerated compliance, according to Mr. Mehta, as jewellers recognised the need to record transactions and operate within the formal economy. The growing jewellery market forms the backdrop for the rush of listings, says Nitant Darekar, research analyst at Bonanza, even as he cautions that the growth reflects price appreciation rather than sales. That creates a key challenge for newly listed

jewellers, he adds. Data from Patterns shows that gold jewellery purchases fell to a 22-quarter low in Q1 2026. The issue gained a macroeconomic dimension recently when Prime Minister Narendra Modi reiterated his appeal to Indians to avoid buying gold unless necessary and to avoid travelling abroad to conserve foreign exchange. The worry is over the impact of elevated gold imports on India's foreign exchange position, even as jewellery becomes less affordable at home. Buyers are increasingly opting for lighter jewellery, lower-carat gold, or studied and diamond jewellery with lower gold con-

tent, says Mr. Kothari, on the mismatch between the value and volume of jewellery sales. Wedding-related purchases continue to provide support, but discretionary and investment-driven demand has slowed, he adds. Of the 21 jewellery IPOs since FY24, eight – including BlueStone Jewellery, PNGS Reva Diamond, Shringar House of Mangal-sutra, Priority Jewels, AJC Jewel Manufacturers, Utsav CZ Gold Jewels and Grover Jewells – were trading with significant gains from debut levels as of September 10. Newly listed Lalitha Jewellery Mart also traded with modest gains. (The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Life insurance surrenders due to mis-selling warrants attention

Aditya Gupta

The recent discussions on the high rate of life insurance surrenders and the likely role played by mis-selling are important and deserve attention. Mis-selling, wherever it occurs, must be addressed firmly. At the same time, aggregate surrender figures should be interpreted with care. The word "surrender" in life insurance statistics covers a wide range of customer behaviour and product structures, and does not always mean that a customer has rejected insurance or the original sale was unsuitable. **Terminology matters** Life insurance and mutual funds use different terminology for similar custom-

er actions. For example, a unit-linked insurance plan (ULIP) combines insurance protection with market-linked investment. After the lock-in period, a policyholder may choose to withdraw or redeem the accumulated value. In the insurance industry, such an exit may be recorded as a "surrender", while it is generally described as "redemption" in the mutual fund industry. The terminology can, therefore, create an impression that every exit represents a failure of the insurance product, when in reality it may simply be the customer's decision to access accumulated funds. Many life insurance products are deliberately designed with long policy durations because insurance



Conditions apply: Mis-selling must be addressed firmly, aggregate surrender figures must be interpreted with care. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

is fundamentally a long-term financial commitment. At the same time, depending on the nature and terms of the product, customers may have access to benefits such as partial withdrawals, surrender or other permitted exit options.

An urgent medical expense, a child's education, a family event, retirement needs or a change in financial priorities can alter the customer's liquidity requirements. Exercising an available exit or withdrawal option in such circumstances should not auto-

matically be construed as dissatisfaction with the product or evidence of mis-selling. To put things in perspective, the ratio of surrender payouts to total life insurance premium collected during the year has progressively increased from 21% in FY20 to 26% in FY25, largely due to the availability of surrender in ULIPs after the 2024 IRDAI regulations. Since ULIPs generally have a lock-in period and combine insurance protection with market-linked investment features, it is apparent that customers have 'redeemed' or 'cashed out' their investment rather than 'surrendered' it. It is always likely that the customer has invested the proceeds in another

protection/ savings policy to improve their financial resilience. A meaningful assessment should distinguish between pure protection products and fund-based or savings-oriented insurance products. For a pure term insurance policy, a surrender or early discontinuance may indeed be a more direct signal that the policyholder no longer wishes to retain the protection. But for ULIPs, participating savings products, and certain single-premium products that combine risk cover with investment or capital appreciation, customer exits can reflect investment decisions, liquidity needs or changes in financial priorities. In some cases, a policyholder may alter the poli-

cy, withdraw value, or reduce the cover without completely ending the insurance relationship or all associated risk protection. Therefore, equating every recorded surrender with complete termination of life insurance protection may oversimplify the actual customer journey. The objective should be to identify genuine mis-selling without unintentionally portraying every customer exit as evidence. To offer a more personalised approach, various life insurers have mandated a personal intervention process. Customers are counselled about the probability of new policies being offered at a higher rate due to advanced age and adverse medical conditions.

Where the policy has been in force only for a short duration, the customer is apprised that the surrender value may not even cover the paid premiums. To help fulfil the temporary need for funds, insurers are offering loan against policies or facilitating partial withdrawal in ULIPs. Future communication campaigns will direct attention towards these measures in a bid to educate customers about the pitfalls of policy surrenders. High surrender numbers should certainly prompt questions, but they should not by themselves become a proxy for mis-selling. (The writer is Secretary General Life Insurance Council)

CAIRO

Two Palestinians killed in Israeli airstrike in Gaza Strip, medics say



▲ An Israeli airstrike on Sunday killed at least two Palestinians in a vehicle and wounded 13 others in the Gaza Strip, medical staff said. The strike occurred in the Tel Al-Hawa neighbourhood in western Gaza City. The Israeli military said the strike targeted two Hamas militants, without giving further information. REUTERS

DOONBEG

‘Negative forces’: Trump slams AI critics, says U.S. leads China in tech



▲ U.S. President Donald Trump said on Sunday a lot of “very negative forces” are bringing things up about AI that won’t happen and said that he wanted to make sure that the U.S. remains the industry leader. “We’re leading China in AI. We’re the most sophisticated country in the world... I want to keep it that way,” Mr. Trump said.

JAKARTA

Search under way for 140 people after Indonesian vessel capsizes



▲ Indonesian rescuers were searching for 140 people from a ship that sank in the Java Sea after 103 others were evacuated, one of whom died, a search and rescue agency official said. An Indonesian passenger ship carrying 243 people had been reported missing after losing contact on Sunday during bad weather. REUTERS

STOCKHOLM

Swedes vote for a new Parliament as far right eyes government role



▲ Sweden voted on Sunday in a tightly contested general election that could either bring the far right into government for the first time or return the left-wing Opposition to power. Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson said he was optimistic that his right-wing alliance, which includes the Sweden Democrats, would emerge victorious. AFP

Pezeshkian says Iran and UAE want to ‘turn the page’ on war

Iranian President’s remarks follow his meeting with Abu Dhabi Crown Prince on the sidelines of a key summit in New Delhi; Iran says meeting planned with Oman today regarding the Strait of Hormuz and enhanced security cooperation in the Gulf

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran and the United Arab Emirates, whose relations have deteriorated since the start of the war in West Asia, want to “turn the page”, Iranian President Massoud Pezeshkian said on Sunday.

“For the first time since the war, we had a constructive exchange with the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi,” said Mr. Pezeshkian a day after a meeting with Sheikh Khaled Bin Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan in New Delhi, on the sidelines of the BRICS summit. “It was agreed that we would turn the page, look to the future and build it together.”

After U.S.-Israeli attacks



Regional rumble: Iran carried retaliatory strikes against America’s allies in the region, with the UAE bearing much of the brunt. REUTERS

on Iran in February launched the war, Tehran retaliated against America’s allies in the region, with the UAE bearing much of the brunt.

Ship strike on Hormuz Meanwhile, Iranian state media reported that an Ira-

nian commercial ship was struck early on Sunday off the Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz and one person was killed in the attack.

Iran’s state-run IRNA news agency quoted the governor of Qeshm, the island crucial for Iran assert-

ing control over the strait, as blaming a “terrorist enemy” for the attack.

Separately, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations monitor said a vessel was hit by a projectile while transiting the strait, with no further details.

The incident occurred a day before Tehran plans to brief countries in the region on its contested efforts to manage shipping traffic at the crucial waterway. The official IRNA news agency reported on Sunday that the meeting with Gulf states in Oman on Monday will be “the first step towards establishing a regional framework for security cooperation” in the region.

Iranian Foreign Ministry

spokesman Esmaeil Baqaei said “it will serve as an essential cornerstone for ensuring stability and security” in a statement.

Tehran has been pushing to formalise its control over the waterway, including charging fees for passage, and has been in negotiations with Muscat, whose territorial waters also cover Hormuz.

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Sunday he does not “care” about the proposed meeting between Iran and Gulf states, while suggesting that the U.S. could stay in Iran and “keep the oil”, drawing a parallel with a U.S. push to take control of a fifth of Venezuela’s vast oil reserves.

(With inputs from Associated Press)

Saudi Arabia pipeline outage puts global oil supply at risk

Reuters
LONDON

Saudi Arabia will run out of oil stocks for exports if it doesn’t restart its major pipeline to the Red Sea within days, leading to a loss of up to 4% of global supply, Saudi oil buyers and traders said.

Since Houthi drone attacks forced Saudi Arabia to shut its huge east-west oil pipeline on Friday, Riyadh has not given full details about the extent of the damage or how long the route will stay off-line.

The world’s biggest exporter has used the pipeline to reroute around 4 million barrels per day – around 4% of global supply – to the port of Yanbu on the Red Sea. But with the pipeline out of service, Yanbu now has stocks to maintain exports for just five to seven days, according to three industry sources.



Desert plume: Satellite image shows smoke rising from an area of Saudi Arabia’s East-West pipeline. AFP

Saudi Arabia also has stocks to supply customers for several days from Egypt’s ports of Ain Sukhna on the Red Sea and Sidi Kerir on the Mediterranean, a fourth source said.

Yanbu storage capacity stands at around 35 million barrels, according to industry estimates, with Ain Sukhna and Sidi Kerir able to store 18 million and 20 million barrels respectively.

Stocks are not full and will ultimately run out

without the east-west pipeline resuming operations, the sources said.

Thousands displaced Tens of thousands have taken flight in the wake of escalating conflict between government forces and Iran-aligned Houthi rebels in Yemen.

“Displacement in Yemen has now reached 85,818 people,” the International Organization for Migration said in a statement.

Top honours



Mathilde Arcel poses with the Coppa Volpi Award for Best Actress, accompanied by May el-Toukhy (left), winner of the Golden Lion Award for Best Film for the movie “Woman Unknown”, during the closing ceremony of the 83rd Venice International Film Festival, Italy, on Saturday. The Danish war drama is the only feature film with a female director in the competition. REUTERS

Canada eyes EU ‘associate member’ status amid U.S tensions, report says

Reuters
BRUSSELS

Canada’s Prime Minister Mark Carney wants a closer relationship with the European Union and is exploring whether his country could become an “associate member” of the bloc, the *Wall Street Journal* reported on Sunday.

The EU, which has not been flexible about membership rules in the past, is open to the idea of granting Canada a yet-to-be-created status of associate membership, the newspaper reported.

Canada’s escalating trade war with the United States has added urgency to its strategic pivot towards other trading partners. Relations between Ottawa and Washington have



Stronger ties: Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and French President Emmanuel Macron are set to meet on September 20. AP

deteriorated sharply, since President Donald Trump returned to the White House last year, due to disagreements over trade and other issues. The trade dispute has led to tariffs on tens of billions of dollars in cross-border trade.

Canada and the EU are

discussing ways of allowing Canada’s goods, services and workers involved in strategic supply chains such as energy, AI, defence and critical minerals to move freely, thus effectively shifting the EU border, the *Wall Street Journal* said.

Canada and the EU are also talking about laying underwater cables, jointly constructing data centres, cloud storage and new satellite networks as well as infrastructure to ship Canadian energy to the EU, the newspaper said.

Mr. Carney has spoken with several EU leaders, most notably French President Emmanuel Macron, about the possibility of letting Canadians live and work visa-free in the EU, the newspaper said, citing two unnamed officials familiar with the matter.

Mr. Macron’s office separately confirmed that he will meet Mr. Carney on September 20 in the French territory of Saint Pierre and Miquelon, a group of islands off Canada’s Atlantic coast.

India slams attack on ship off Oman coast, one seafarer missing

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India on Sunday condemned an attack on a Panama-flagged oil tanker off the coast of Oman that resulted in one Indian seafarer being reported missing.

The External Affairs Ministry said 13 other Indian crew members of the vessel, *MT El Gaia*, were rescued.

“We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel *MT El Gaia* off the coast of Oman earlier to-

day. Of the 14 Indian crew onboard, 13 Indians have been rescued so far,” it said.

“Search and rescue operations for the missing Indian national are continuing,” the Ministry said in a statement.

“We reiterate our call for immediate de-escalation of tensions and pursuance of dialogue and diplomacy to bring peace to the region,” it said.

Ten Indian seafarers have been killed so far in the West Asia conflict.

Myanmar revokes status of UN envoy, says official holding office illegitimately

Agence France-Presse
YANGON

Myanmar’s military-backed government said on Sunday their UN Ambassador – loyal to ousted leader Aung San Suu Kyi – is occupying the office illegitimately, as the organisation prepares to weigh his replacement.

Myanmar has been embroiled in civil war since a military coup in 2021 ousted the elected government of Nobel laureate Suu Kyi.

The United Nations formed a credentials committee this month to de-



Kyaw Moe Tun

cide whether to accept Naypyidaw’s candidate for UN ambassador or stick with Kyaw Moe Tun, who has rejected the coup and

for more than five years ignored the government’s claims that he no longer represents Myanmar.

Myanmar’s Foreign Ministry said Kyaw Moe Tun was “dismissed from civil service” effective February 27, 2021 for not complying with state orders, committing treason and colluding with “terrorist organisations”, according to a statement published in the state-run *Global New Light of Myanmar* newspaper.

The day before his dismissal, he made an emotional plea during an address at the UN General

Assembly for the “strongest possible action” against the military coup.

The Ministry accused Kyaw Moe Tun of misusing state funds and property, including the premises of the UN Permanent Mission of Myanmar in New York, and working with the exiled opposition “National Unity Government” (NUG), which the government has branded a terrorist group.

“Kyaw Moe Tun’s continued representation of Myanmar at the UN does not constitute formal recognition of his legitimacy,” the Ministry said.

Turkiye authorities launch crackdown on LGBTQ+ associations

Reuters
ISTANBUL

Turkish authorities have detained at least 47 people following a series of raids on the offices of LGBTQ+ associations in a probe into prostitution and obscenity, prosecutors said.

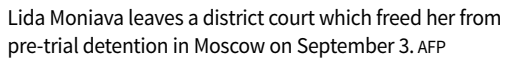
The Istanbul chief prosecutor’s office said operations were carried out over the weekend across 12 provinces against 38 suspects, and 26 of them were detained with authorities seizing drugs, digital

equipment, smuggled alcohol and a firearm.

LGBTQ+ association Kaos GL said at least 50 activists had been detained.

Dubbed “My Family is Safe”, the crackdown is part of a campaign that the Tayyip Erdogan-led government says is aimed at protecting family values.

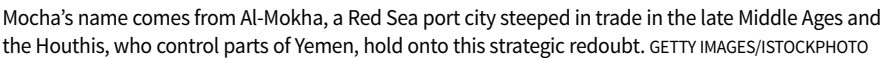
“The real name of this operation is not ‘My Family is Safe’; it is state-led discrimination and the dismantling of civil society,” the Turkish Human Rights Association said on X.



Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

"But I cannot stay silent as if there is no war."

Yemen is where the world's first coffee farms came up, writes Jonathan Morris in his book, *Coffee: A Global History*. Ethiopia remained the sole source of coffee until the 1540s, but as supplies dwindled due to internal conflict,



The Yemeni rulers jealously guarded their coffee and allowed no fertile seed to leave the port of Al-Mokha so that cultivation spreading elsewhere would deny their country a golden goose. While returning to India from his Haj pilgrimage, the Sufi saint Baba Budan travelled

The India connection started even earlier, as Al-Mok-

ha had been a bustling port through which the world's trade transited. "The coffee would then pass through various intermediaries before ending up in the major wholesale market of Bayt al-Fahsal located on the coastal plain. Here, it was bought by merchants and held in warehouses, prior to being transported by camel train to the ports of Al-Makha [otherwise known as Al-Mocha, Al-Mokka and, to Europeans, Mocha] and

“There was water, but it was muddy,” he said. “I only had that.” Another worker, Kabir Maharjan, 45, had survived nearby. “We were separated but speaking to each other.” The ability to hear another human voice offered a lifeline to Mr. Sah. Eventually, search teams broke through and brought them out alive.

Decoding colours: People attend the 'Art Has an Impact' exhibition at the National Centre for Visual Arts in Damascus, on September 13. It features 197 artists from different generations and backgrounds, both residing in Syria and abroad. AFP

For others, like Ms. Aminolla, money will never be the answer. "We're angry because we are not being given the right answers," she said of her missing brother. "Why is the government still sleeping?"



SUDHAKARA JAIN

INTERVIEW

Magnus Carlsen

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Magnus Carlsen relinquished his crown four years ago. But he continues to rule the chess world. He drew the biggest applause at the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, which concluded in Bengaluru on Sunday. On a fine evening at the Lalit Ashok, the World No. 1 from Norway spoke on a variety of topics.

Excerpts:

On the newly launched Total Chess World Championship Tour

I think it is an important step for chess to rate slightly faster games as classical. We have needed a more universal system of rating every tournament game for a long time. Attempts have been made, but it has always been that the classical rating has been the gold standard.

And every tournament that doesn't have a classical rating for certain people matters less for this reason. So I am happy that Total Chess can both be classically rated and be a mix of formats that makes it harder for people to master weaknesses.

On D. Gukesh's defence of the World title in his upcoming match against Javokhir Sindarov

I think the word defence is really not a good place to begin. Because in terms of how Gukesh has played for the last couple of years, he should not be in a position where he has to defend anything. He should be in a position where he has everything to gain.

And yeah, he has shown previously in 2024 that he has, when things click, the potential to play at an extremely high level. And I don't think a lot of people believe that he will do it now, but I think it is even more of an interesting challenge for him to try and get back to that.

And chess is a highly psychological game. So it probably won't take a lot to potentially place some doubts in Sindarov's mind and for Gukesh to get some confidence. As it stands, there is no question that Sindarov is the favourite.

But in that World championship match, all you need is to win a game or to, as chess is such a drawish game. And Gukesh has shown that his ceiling is on par or better than Sindarov. There is no doubt about that.

And the other thing is that it is a short match. The first few games can determine a lot. If Sindarov is ahead early on, it is probably very, very bad news for Gukesh. If Gukesh is ahead early on, he automatically becomes a significant favourite. That is how these

matches work.

About R. Praggnanandhaa who has been in red-hot form on the chessboard

I think he has a very good foundation in chess. But he plays in a very aggressive way. And it has been working out really well for him recently. I don't think his approach has changed too much.

I am a fan. I love watching his chess. He pushes his opponents very, very hard. He manages to put pressure on basically everybody, including myself. But I think he is still not at a point where he can say that he has distanced himself from his peers. He is not quite consistent enough for that.

About the Global Chess League

It has a really good format. I have said from the start that we need team formats in chess that are genuinely exciting.

The lack of increments is very good. I would have preferred not to have the two-second increment after 40 moves as well. I think it was implemented on the request of us players who are incompetent and lazy at times.

Also this is the format where you have the very clear white against black. Matches are staggered, which is very good. The matches are always going to be decisive unless all six games are drawn.

There are just a lot of good things about the GCL. I would also like to come to India every second year or so. Because I need a year off to remind myself how crowded the tournaments are and all of that. But parts of it I really enjoy. There is no atmosphere or enthusiasm for chess in the rest of the world.

The impact of AI on chess

I am not a computer expert, so I don't know if chess is going to be solved (by the

computer). Chess is semi-solved in the sense that we are pretty sure that it is a draw. And it is a draw in a ton of ways. The margin is quite big.

AI and computers in general have made the game a lot more accessible. You are now able to follow it, see the score. For the pros, it has made it, after an initial period of excitement, even more egalitarian than it was before.

The possibility of coming back to the classical World championship cycle

After I became a father as well, I am even more certain that I will never come back to the classical World championship. There are so many things that I like about chess. There are a lot of tournaments that I like. There are a lot of formats that I like. Even classical, especially faster times of classical, maybe not as a steady diet, but at least once in a while. I can't justify spending a ton of time on something that I genuinely dislike.

Also, there is no competitive reason why I should. It makes zero sense for me. I am satisfied with being five-time World champion rather than a six-time World champion. Well, there are other world championship formats as well. Fifteen-time World champion in rapid and blitz - that is quite a lot more than everybody else.

The crowd at the GCL in Bengaluru

The crowd has been good. I love it when chess tournaments have good experiences for the public.

**The favourites
in the open
section of the
Chess Olympiad
which begins**

at Samarkand on Tuesday

India, Uzbekistan and the USA are all incredible teams. Considering what happened last time, I think India is still the team to beat.

The way the players, including him, are introduced to the audience before every match at the GCL

It is nice to remind myself of some of the things that I have won.

Playing golf at the Bangalore Golf Club before his GCL games

I go there and I try to hit the ball.
Sometimes I hit it, sometimes not.
Sometimes it goes in the hole,



sometimes it goes in the woods,
sometimes it goes in the water,
sometimes in the fairway.

Footballers Erling Haaland and Gerard Pique investing in chess

I think it is great. A lot of celebrities, not only from football, have an interest in chess. And it speaks of how chess has become part of popular culture a lot more during the last five, six years.

His future in chess

It is not going to be forever. At the moment, I am taking a few years at a time. It is hard to imagine me completely stepping away from competitive chess as long as I am pretty good at it. And also because I like playing.

MADHYA PRADESH



Victims of the Madhya Pradesh hooch tragedy, who have lost their vision, being treated at Bundelkhand Medical College in Sagar district. A.M. FARUQUI A.M. FARUQUI

Moonshine hits a deadly blind spot in Sagar

A spurious liquor outbreak across several villages in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district has killed 16 people and left more than 150 ill, with several victims suffering severe vision loss; more than 30 remain under treatment. **Mehul Malpani** traces the tragedy through the deaths linked to methyl alcohol poisoning, the police investigation into an alleged counterfeit liquor network and the harrowing accounts of victims' families

Rajdhar Sen lies on a bed in the ward of the Netra Rog Vibhag (Ophthalmology Department) at the Bundelkhand Medical College (BMC) in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district, surrounded by his family members. At every sound, Rajdhar gets up, frantically turning his head in all directions, and tries to speak something. Rajdhar, 49, a resident of Sagar district's Budna village in Shahgarh tehsil, has lost his vision almost entirely after drinking spurious or moonshine liquor that has so far killed 16 people in the region.

"Shanivar ko humne laal waala piya tha ₹80 ka. Pahle safed peetey the, lekin ye laal wala humayi basti mein milan laga tha toh le liya. Humayi tabiyat bigdi savere chaar baje, saans phoolne lagi or ulti hui. Teen din se kuch nahi dikh raha hai, apka chehra nahi dikh raha hai sirf kala-kala, dhundhla dikh raha hai. (On Saturday [September 5], I drank the red liquor, which costs ₹80. Earlier, I used to drink the white one, but the red variety became available in my neighbourhood, so I bought it. I fell ill at 4 a.m.; I started gasping for breath first and then vomited. For the last three days, I haven't been able to see anything clearly – I can't make out your face; everything just looks like a dark, hazy blur," says Rajdhar, who works as a mason. He slurs as he narrates his ordeal, which is quite similar to those lying on the neighbouring beds in the ward.

For several villages in Sagar's Banda and Shahgarh subdivisions, the intervening night of September 5 and 6 came with chaos and panic as men started to collapse with dizziness, seizures and loss of vision. Their family members rushed them to the nearest medical centres, mostly to the Government Civil Hospital, Banda.

As the number of patients increased, the doctors at the civil hospital informed the local administration and by 5.30 a.m. the District Collector and Magistrate of Sagar Pratibha Pal received a call from Superintendent of Police Anurag Sujania, prompting her to rush to Banda.

Some patients were brought dead to Banda, others died on the hospital premises, while several others were immediately referred to different government hospitals in Sagar, including Government District Hospital and BMC located on Tili Road in Vaishali Nagar. By September 6, 11 people had died in one of the worst hooch tragedies in Madhya Pradesh in the last five years.

The official death toll has now gone up to 16 even as local residents and media reports peg the numbers above 30.

On September 6, the police lodged two separate cases at Banda and Binaika police stations, accusing as many as 30 people.

Over the past one week, 17 of them have been arrested, including the key accused Chandrabhan Rajput alias Chandu Raja and Ravi Lakhera, who was held on September 11. On September 6, three Excise Department officials, including an Assistant Commissioner, were suspended for negligence and failing to act on the ground despite recent complaints about illicit liquor being sold openly in the villages. Deputy Commissioner (Excise) and in-charge of the Divisional Flying Squad Neerja Srivastava was attached to the Gwalior headquarters. Two police officers, including Banda station in-charge Rajendra Singh Kushwaha, were also suspended.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, who visited Sagar on Wednesday, issued orders for a judicial probe into the matter. "The police have demonstrated their efficiency, and this is why I had issued the instructions for strict action. We will not spare anyone. We will also launch a campaign against drug abuse across the State and deal strictly with those responsible for such incidents," Yadav said on Friday.

Mourning and anger

A drive from Banda to surrounding villages during the monsoon is punctuated by a serene landscape, dotted by small hills. However, sorrow and fury define the emotional climate in these villages. At the first T-point of the Bamura Bheda village in Sagar's Banda tehsil, one sees people sitting on



You could get countrymade cheap liquor in every village. People would get liquor stock illegally from licensed government shops in nearby villages and sell them from anywhere in our village.

DESHRAJ LODHI
A resident of Gugra Khurd

plastic chairs. They are the friends and family members of the four persons who lived in the three houses located at the T-point and died after drinking spurious liquor.

Badi Bahu, 66, sits alone at the gate of her broken house. She lost her son, Rajkumar Lodhi, 35, who worked as a labourer and was the family's only breadwinner, to the tragedy. Badi Bahu is now alone; her husband died about six years ago.

"He drank alcohol before he returned home from work and slept. Then he woke me up in the middle of the night and said that he was not feeling well. Before I could understand anything, he fainted. Since I cannot walk properly, neighbours took him to the hospital but he could not be saved. I don't know where he bought the liquor from or who made him drink but I am now left alone," she says, cursing her fate.

In the neighbouring house, a family lost two of its members – Govind Lodhi, 62, and his eldest son Ram Prasad Lodhi, 40. The younger son, Bhoore Lodhi, 35, is currently being treated at BMC. Inside, a group of women sit on the floor mourning and blaming the authorities for failing to check the illicit liquor trade in the region.

Govind's daughter Maya Lodhi, 30, says, "Of the three men in our family, two are gone and one is struggling in the hospital. It's just women and children left and none of us work. My brother [Ram Prasad] has left two daughters and a younger son. They are all in school and his wife is ill. Who will take their responsibility?"

Maya says that the ₹4 lakh compensation, announced by the government for each deceased's family, is not enough. "Can we educate and marry all the children with this money," she asks. The family also raises questions over the facilities at government hospitals saying that "had their family members received proper treatment at Banda Civil Hospital, they could have been saved."

"The government has made hospitals but forgot to check if the staffers and doctors work properly or not. They just sit and prescribe medicines without properly checking the patients or getting any tests done. They don't care how the patient is feeling," says Maya.

In another house, Dinesh Singh Dangri, 41, says his brother Sumer Singh Dangri, 45, died after suffering seizures and losing his vision due to the spurious alcohol.

"He first complained of chest pain and high blood pressure; we thought it was a heart attack. We immediately rushed him to Banda Civil hospital, but on the way he experienced stiffness in his body and vomited white, foam-like liquid. A little amount of the same liquid came out of his eyes too. He stopped responding in the car so I started pumping his chest. He could not make it to the hospital. His body turned blue," says Dinesh, adding "nobody should die like this".

Bamura Bheda has lost six persons to the tragedy. About 25 kilometres away, in Gugra Khurd village five persons have died after drinking spurious liquor. Neelesh Lodhi, 30, a labourer from the village was referred to Hamidia Hospital in Bhopal for better treatment but could not survive.

His family blames the doctors for negligence.

Neelesh's brother-in-law, Jasvendra Lodhi, says that the doctors in Bhopal asked him to find an injection. "They said it was necessary to save his life. Some relatives and I ran from one pharmacy to another but could not find it. When we told the doctors, they said they could not do anything and it was our responsibility to find the injection," he says. Jasvendra says that he lodged a complaint against the doctor with the Chief Minister's helpline. "After that I have received two-three calls from the same doctor asking me to withdraw my complaint, but I refused," he adds.

A tragedy awaits

More than 150 people from several villages in the region have so far fallen ill due to the spurious liquor, as per official figures. More than 30 are still undergoing treatment. Collector Pal says that the official death toll, which is 16 people so far, has been recorded based on the post-mortem reports. She says that viscera samples of several other deceased, whose families claimed that they died due to the spurious liquor, have been sent for forensic tests to ascertain the exact cause of deaths.

"Viscera samples of some people, whose post-mortem reports did not link their deaths to counterfeit liquor or did not show an exact cause of death, have been sent for forensic analysis. If it is shown in the reports, we will have no hesitation in including them in the toll," she says.

Across villages, there is a wave of anger against the administration. Villagers allege that illicit liquor has been sold openly in villages for years from *kirana* shops and even houses. "You could get countrymade cheap liquor in every village. People would get liquor stock illegally from licensed government shops in nearby villages and sell them from anywhere in our village," says Deshraj Lodhi, a resident of Gugra Khurd.

Youth in various villages say that about two years ago, locals had formed local committees against the sale and consumption of liquor within the village.

"The rule was that if anybody wants to drink, they could at their homes because men would drink outside and cause accidents or get into fights. We also started giving complaints about those selling liquor in the village to the police, but it did not work because the police would barely come to take any action. Even if they came sometimes, they would take the person selling the liquor with them and he would return in a few days. And in the meantime, their family members, including women, would continue the business," adds Deshraj.

The committees, however, had to be disbanded in most villages as they lacked support from the authorities and would cause animosity among locals. The fear persists even after the tragedy with locals hesitating to name those who sold liquor in their villages.

Anil Thakur, 28, a resident of Bamura Bheda, says, "Even now, families of some people who have been arrested came to fight with us as they believe that we gave their names. We can't tell you who the people are because it would cause fights in the village."

Collector Pal admits the lapse and says that the administration has formed a special team to run a campaign against intoxication and addiction in the region. "These teams will work in the villages and also try to revive these old committees so that they can work more effectively," she says.

Hariom Chaturvedi, a lawyer and activist based in Banda, says that most licensed liquor shops in the region would get illegal stock from the distilleries and then supply it to villages. "Over the years, they started a 'diary system' to maintain the records of illegal liquor. This was to divide their areas of supply," he adds.

Nexus of illicit liquor

In the wake of the tragedy, a few popular brands of cheap liquor, including Sagar Gold of DCR Distillery and illicitly made Bambaiya Whiskey, invit-

ed suspicion. Locals identify them as red and white liquor. This led to the Excise Department issuing orders to prohibit the sale of Sagar Gold.

However, days of investigation and questioning of accused revealed a bigger conspiracy and nexus of counterfeit liquor made using the name of Sagar Gold, by the prime accused Chandrabhan Rajput, Lakhera and Manish Lodhi, who owns a licensed liquor shop in Barethi village in Shahgarh tehsil.

As per police records seen by *The Hindu*, Rajput, divisional president of Karni Sena and a resident of Shahgarh's Tatarwara village, came in contact with Manish through a relative, Shivanjay Rajput. Manish further connected him to Lakhera, an inter-State liquor smuggler and a resident of Uttar Pradesh's Lalitpur district, who arranged the liquor-making formula for them. The three then planned on manufacturing counterfeit liquor. Two days before *Jannmashtami*, Lakhera supplied raw material such as spirit, packaging material and wrapper of Sagar Gold brand.

A senior police officer says Rajput, Manish and Shivanjay then made counterfeit liquor with Sagar Gold's name in Rajput's maize field in Tatarwara village, and supplied 50 cartons of it in various villages through salesmen.

The two FIRs show that the counterfeit liquor was sold for about ₹60 and ₹70 per quarter bottle, ₹20-₹30 cheaper than actual Sagar Gold which is sold for ₹100. The locals who got suspicious were assured that it was the same liquor brand and had come from Manish's licensed shop.

SP Sujania says that it has been confirmed that the deaths were caused by methyl alcohol poisoning. The Collector says that the test reports of the counterfeit liquor seized from the accused are still awaited. "But it is suspected that they had mixed high percentage of methyl alcohol in the liquor," Pal said. Sujania admits that the police had received intelligence about the network of counterfeit liquor in the region. "We had started working on it but it took us some time to develop on the inputs. We made a small error in this but we tried our best to avoid this incident," he adds. Sujania says that as soon as the tragedy came to light, the accused destroyed a large quantity of counterfeit liquor and materials used in the manufacturing but the police managed to seize some items, including 164 empty bottles of Sagar Gold and plain liquor, 170 bottle caps, 150 labels along with other items and hundreds of litres of illicit liquor.

While the police have arrested 17 people in the case so far, various accused including Manish remain at large.

Chaturvedi, however, claims that the network of illicit liquor goes far beyond the men named in the cases and alleges "involvement and protection" of several senior political leaders of the district. He says that some of the prime accused in the case have political connections and are often seen with powerful leaders. "The police and the administration are aware of all these networks but how will they act against anyone who has such powerful friends," he asks.

Senior Congress leader and former Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh Digvijaya Singh alleges that the business of making illicit liquor "could not have been run without the administration's approval and cooperation".

"Should we not acknowledge the involvement of the administration, government officials, and the Minister whose name has surfaced?" Singh asked, without naming anyone. Singh's remarks, however, drew a response from former MLA and BJP leader from Sagar Arunoday Choubey who claimed that the Congress leader was making misleading claims by linking "accused Sidhharth Kushwaha to [BJP Minister] Govind Singh Rajput", a powerful leader from Sagar.

Singh has gone on to allege that illicit liquor is being sold in the State at about 1,700 locations.

"Why are they letting this happen? Why has no action been taken on this as this also impacts the government's revenue. This is happening because somewhere the administration and BJP leaders are involved in this," he said Saturday.

mehul.malpani@thehindu.co.in

